

Fire on the Mountain



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF ANITA DESAI

Anita Desai was born in the Himalayan foothills, in the town of Mussoorie, India, in 1937. Her father, D. N. Mazumdar, was a businessman originally from the Bengal region, while her mother had immigrated to India from Germany. When they married in the 1930s, it was uncommon for Indian men to marry European women. Desai and her three siblings grew up in New Delhi. They spoke German at home, English at school, and Hindi with their neighbors. Desai attended the University of Delhi, where she earned a degree in English literature in 1957. In 1958, she married Ashvin Desai, with whom she had four children. Desai loved writing from an early age. Her first short story was published when she was nine years old, but she didn't find widespread acclaim until the publication of *Cry the Peacock* in 1963. Her subsequent body of work includes novels, short story collections, and children's books. Her work has won prestigious prizes including the Guardian Children's Fiction Prize, and she is a member of the British Royal Society of Literature and the American Academy of Arts and Letters. Starting in the late 1980s, Desai held a series of academic posts in the United States, teaching creative writing at Mount Holyoke College, Baruch College, Smith College, and the Massachusetts Institute of Technology.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Nanda Kaul and Ila Das grow up in the waning years of the British rule in India. Although the British had been involved in colonial projects in India from the 17th century, it wasn't until 1858 that the British Crown under Queen Victoria assumed direct control over India from the East India Company. The British had always faced uprisings and revolts in India, but events in the early decades of the 20th century led to a vote by Parliament in 1945 to decolonize India. Reasons for the decision included global sympathy and appreciation for India as a founding member of the United Nations; the high-profile protests of Mahatma Gandhi, his followers, and others; and the toll World War II took on Britain. In formally dissolving the British Raj, Britain divided its former holdings between the majority-Hindu India and the majority-Muslim Pakistan, thanks in part to ongoing agitation by Muslim separatists. The division, called the Indian Partition, led to massive upheaval, violence, and death in the affected areas, which were primarily in the northern part of the country. Kashmir, where Nanda Kaul grew up, was claimed by both India and Pakistan, leading to outright war in 1947–1948 and tensions which have simmered—and occasionally broken out into renewed violence—in the decades

since.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Fire on the Mountain centers on the experience of Nanda Kaul, who has retired in her widowhood to an isolated cottage high atop a mountain. The physical isolation of her home, Desai's literary choices—including shifting between the perspectives of Nanda Kaul, Raka, and Ila Das, and the novel's thematic exploration of both the importance of friendships and familial relationships and the ways in which responsibilities can entrap and diminish women recall Virginia Woolf's [To the Lighthouse](#) (1927). Anita Desai's daughter, Kiran Desai, riffs on the familial setup of *Fire on the Mountain* in her 2005 book [The Inheritance of Loss](#), which sees an elderly widower and his faithful cook playing host to the widower's granddaughter. Like *Fire on the Mountain*, [The Inheritance of Loss](#) explores themes of loss and family, but it places a heavier emphasis on the enduring effects of the British colonial project on the Indian subcontinent. In this vein, Geetanjali Shree's *Tomb of Sand*, published in 2018, explores themes of family, love, loss, and change as it follows its 80-year-old protagonist and her daughter on a trip to Pakistan, to places the mother left behind as a teenager during Indian Partition. All these books share *Fire on the Mountain*'s attention to language and lean heavily on imagery, puns, and a skillful manipulation of language to convey characters' emotional lives.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Fire on the Mountain
- **When Written:** 1970s
- **Where Written:** India
- **When Published:** 1977
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel, Realism
- **Setting:** A house situated in a small Indian town in the Himalayan foothills
- **Climax:** Ila Das is murdered, and Raka starts a wildfire
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Place of the Gods. Monkey Point got its name because according to legend, the Hindu god Hanuman (who has monkey-like characteristics) stepped down there as he descended from the Himalayas bearing a magical herb.

Wild Things. In the book, Raka becomes fascinated with the Pasteur Institute, which manufactures rabies vaccines among

other things. Rabies was—and still is—a significant health risk in India, which accounts for 36 percent of global rabies infections thanks to its large population of stray dogs. Fortunately, safe and effective modern vaccines are 100 percent effective against death if administered in a timely and correct manner.



PLOT SUMMARY

Elderly Nanda Kaul lives in a cottage called Carignano in the foothills of northern India with no one but her cook, Ram Lal, for company. She came here after her children were grown and her husband, the Vice-Chancellor of an Indian university, died. She cherishes the solitude and isolation of her widowhood—until her family sends her great-granddaughter Raka to Carignano to recuperate from a bout of typhoid.

Raka is a quiet, withdrawn child who prefers solitude. She rarely speaks to Nanda Kaul, and she spends most of her time exploring the countryside, especially the **ravine** that runs below the ridge. It is a dangerous place, full of trash, potentially rabid **jackals**, and even—according to Ram Lal—evil spirits. The one time Nanda Kaul insists on walking with Raka to nearby Monkey Point, Raka makes no secret of her displeasure over the intrusion. Nanda Kaul, in turn, resents Raka's independence. To try to tempt the child into friendship, Nanda Kaul starts telling her fabulous tales about her childhood.

Over the summer, Raka sneaks onto the grounds of the nearby Kasauli Club on the night of their summer party. The masquerade ball, with its costumed and erratic revelers, scares her because it reminds her of times when her father came home drunk and heaped abuse on her mother, Tara. Not long afterward, she sees her first wildfire burning on some distant hills. Wildfires are common in the area during the hot, dry summers.

Then, Nanda Kaul's childhood friend Ila Das comes to tea at Carignano. Nanda Kaul and Ila Das grew up together as the privileged daughters of upper-class families. But Ila Das's brothers squandered the family's fortune, leaving her and her sister Rima destitute. Nanda Kaul twice rescued her, first by getting the Vice-Chancellor to offer her a job at the college and then (after the Vice-Chancellor's death and Ila Das's resignation) by helping her to get a job as a government welfare worker. Now she makes a meager living trying to encourage rural villagers to turn from outdated practices like child marriage and folk medicine and to embrace modern medicine and progressive social mores. She struggles to survive on her paltry salary.

At tea with Nanda Kaul one day, Ila Das reminisces about the good old days. But the charmed mood breaks when she mentions Miss David, the Vice-Chancellor's long-term mistress. Nanda Kaul makes it clear that the tea is over and it is time for Ila Das to leave. Although they both know that she

needs help, Ila Das cannot bring herself to ask for it, and Nanda Kaul cannot bring herself to offer it.

As Ila Das sets out for her home deep in the valley, Raka steals a box of matches from the kitchen and sneaks into the ravine. Ila Das stops by the Kasauli bazaar, even though she's too poor to afford anything. Before she reaches the safety of her hut, a villager named Preet Singh, enraged by her attempt to interfere in the marriage of his seven-year-old daughter, attacks her. He strangles and rapes her and leaves her body by the side of the road.

The police call Nanda Kaul at Carignano and ask her to come identify Ila Das's body. As she struggles to comprehend the news, Raka knocks on the windowpane, summoning her great-grandmother to witness the wildfire she has started in the ravine.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Nanda Kaul – Nanda Kaul is an elderly Indian woman who grew up in a privileged family. She married the Vice-Chancellor and spent much of her adult life rearing their children, managing their servants, and helping her husband burnish his reputation by hosting guests in their home. The Vice-Chancellor's affair with Miss David was an open secret that wounded Nanda Kaul deeply. She felt little affection for her children when they were young, resenting their needs and demands on her time and attention. After her children had grown and her husband died, she moved to Carignano with only Ram Lal for company. She tells herself that isolation is what she wants. The degree to which this is untrue becomes clear when her great-granddaughter Raka comes to stay with her. Nanda Kaul is jealous of Raka's sense of freedom and independence—she wants the child to need her and tries to impose herself on Raka's world by means of storytelling. It's clear from her interactions with Ila Das that Nanda Kaul is a faithful friend. Not only has Nanda Kaul rescued her friend from poverty twice, but she also allows Ila Das to breach the isolation of Carignano for a visit. Ultimately, however, Nanda Kaul remains so wedded to the image she has of herself as an isolated, nun-like figure that she can't bring herself to offer the help she knows Ila Das needs, a failure that leads to tragic consequences for them both.

Raka – Raka is Nanda Kaul's great-granddaughter. Her mother Tara is the daughter of Nanda's daughter Asha. Raka's name means "moon," but she is a slight, angular child. She is fascinated by and drawn to wild places like the **ravine** and the **burned cottage**, and she feels an affinity with wild **animals**. She values her independence and freedom above everything else, and this makes her fearless even in the face of the warnings Ram Lal offers her. She doesn't have any friends her age. She easily sees

through the lies Nanda Kaul and Ila Das tell, and she accepts her mother's frequent illness stoically. She comes to resent Nanda Kaul's neediness over the summer she spends at Carignano, and she finds Ila Das—with her loud, screeching voice and her sanitized memories—abhorrent. Although Nanda Kaul at first envies Raka for her apparent freedom and independence, the narrative later suggests that Raka's constant solitude is not in fact a sign of her independence and self-confidence, at least not entirely. Instead, it perhaps reflects Raka's inability to connect with others, a consequence of the confusing turmoil she has witnessed in her home life.

Ila Das – Ila Das is Nanda Kaul's childhood friend. Although she grew up with privilege and wealth, her childhood was rendered difficult by the terrible sound of her voice, which caused other children to make fun of her. Further calamity befell her and her sister Rima when their brothers squandered the family fortune. Although nothing in her upbringing prepared her to do so, Ila Das was forced to work to support herself for most of her life. At Nanda Kaul's urging, the Vice-Chancellor created a position for Ila Das at the university. Later, Nanda Kaul arranges for Ila Das to work as a welfare worker, encouraging rural villagers to embrace modern medicine and to abandon outdated, unjust practices like child marriage. Although she's lived on the edge of poverty for many years, she still clings to class distinctions, she shows her callous disregard for the lower classes in her occasional fraught interactions with the grainseller and Preet Singh. Ila Das is too proud to ask Nanda Kaul or anyone else for charity or help. This, combined with her refusal to back down, leads to her untimely death at the hands of Preet Singh, who murders her after she seeks to thwart his efforts to marry off his young daughter to a much older man.

Ram Lal – Ram Lal is Nanda Kaul's elderly cook, although he helps with other chores around Carignano, too. He strikes up a friendship with Raka, telling her stories about Kasauli's past as well as a few ghost tales and legends. He has a sense of propriety, even though it's clearly been a long time since he served in a fancy home.

Vice-Chancellor – The Vice-Chancellor was Nanda Kaul's husband. He insisted on maintaining high standards, and for this reason his house was filled with expensive things, and his wife always wore silks and jewels. The Vice-Chancellor married Nanda Kaul because he felt it necessary to marry an Indian woman, even though he conducted a lifelong affair with his British colleague at the university, Miss David.

Asha – Asha is one of Nanda Kaul's and the Vice-Chancellor's many children. She was a lovely child who grew up to be a lovely woman who married well. She spends most of her time fussing over her own daughters Tara and Vina. Nanda Kaul finds Asha to be her most trying child. It's Asha's idea to send Raka to Carignano to recuperate.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Father – Nanda Kaul's father was a wealthy businessman. He features heavily in the stories Nanda Kaul tells Raka. As a character in these tales, he travels to exotic locations, cultivates exotic fruits, and keeps exotic **animals** as pets.

Tara – Tara is one of Asha's daughters. She is married to an abusive and philandering diplomat, and she is Raka's mother. Her many struggles cause her to experience frequent breakdowns of physical and mental health.

Vina – Vina is one of Asha's daughters. It's because of her impending childbirth that Asha cannot take care of Raka herself and instead sends Raka to stay with Nanda Kaul at Carignano.

Rima – Rima is Ila Das's sister. An accomplished pianist, she makes a living for a time by offering lessons, but she eventually falls into crushing poverty.

Miss David – Miss David is the mathematics instructor with whom the Vice-Chancellor conducts a lifelong affair.

Grainseller – The grainseller is a shopkeeper in the Kasauli bazaar who is kind to Ila Das.

Preet Singh – Preet Singh is a villager who resents Ila Das's interference in his attempts to marry off his seven-year-old daughter for financial gain. He murders Ila Das in retaliation.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



THE NATURE OF FREEDOM

When *Fire on the Mountain* begins, Nanda Kaul tells herself that she has the life she's always wanted.

She lives in an austere cottage in the Himalayan foothills, with only her cook Ram Lal as company. Nanda Kaul thinks her isolation is freedom. In the context of her married life—when she was responsible for raising a mob of children and supporting the career of a husband who never loved her (the Vice-Chancellor)—this association makes sense. But when her great-granddaughter Raka arrives at Carignano, it becomes clear that Nanda Kaul neither wants to be alone nor to be released from the care of others. She wants Raka to like—and depend on—her. And she feels sad and resentful when Raka doesn't.

In contrast to her great-grandmother, Raka does find freedom in isolation. She spends most of her time exploring isolated areas like the **ravine** and the **burned cottage** with only **animals** for company. Even when she's close to other people, she tends to make herself invisible. The book suggests that Nanda Kaul resents Raka both for rejecting her and for really having the

thing that Nanda Kaul most wants: freedom. And because she associates freedom with isolation, she tries to squash her urges to connect with Raka and to help her unfortunate friend Ila Das. But Nanda Kaul gradually realizes that isolation isn't what she truly wants. For her, freedom means the ability to form connections with others that aren't based on responsibility but on mutual affection. And she comes to understand that her isolation—a reaction to her inability to connect with her children and the Vice-Chancellor's rejection of her love—is just as painful a trap as her domestic life once was. She *longs* to help her friend, just as she longs to make a connection with Raka. Too late, Nanda Kaul starts to realize that true freedom lies in understanding and embracing her true nature and real desires. Only when she discovers her true feelings and honors them can she—or, by extension, anyone else—find personal freedom.



HONESTY AND SELF-REFLECTION

In its three central characters—Nanda Kaul, Raka, and Ila Das—*Fire on the Mountain* demonstrates two different orientations toward the truth and self-knowledge. All three must contend with painful things. But while Raka cannot deny her nature or her truth, both Nanda Kaul and Ila Das spin stories and reinvent history to protect themselves from pain. Ila Das's pride prevents her from admitting her need or asking for help. Nanda Kaul's tortured feelings about Raka show that she doesn't like her isolation as much as she wants others—and herself—to believe. She lies both to lure Raka into friendship and to make her current situation more bearable. But Raka sees through this dishonesty, and in the end, the only person Nanda Kaul deceives is herself.

In contrast, Raka lives honestly, even when it's difficult. She knows she's no good at social interactions, so she keeps to herself. She wants to be told the truth about her mother Tara's breakdowns. And her arrival in Nanda Kaul's life sets in motion a reckoning with the truth that is long overdue for the elderly woman. In the book's final chapters, Raka steals a box of matches and sparks a wildfire in the **ravine** that threatens to burn away Nanda Kaul's carefully constructed house of lies. Simultaneously, Nanda Kaul learns of Ila Das's tragic—and preventable—death. This moment or reckoning is the crux of the book: Nanda Kaul can no longer maintain the lies she tells herself about her imperviousness. The book thus offers a warning about the dangers of dishonesty and the value of self-reflection. Like the wildfires that regularly visit the hills, the truth can be painful and sometimes destructive. But it's also what clears away the detritus cluttering the ravine, just as honest self-reflection and acceptance is the foundation of a life that's safe, secure, and at peace with one's true nature.



TRAUMA AND SUFFERING

The subjects of *Fire on the Mountain* must contend with tragedy, suffering, and loss. The villagers under Ila Das's care suffer from starvation and preventable diseases. Ram Lal reminds Raka more than once about his scary dog bite and the painful series of shots he endured to prevent rabies. Raka is sickly and has witnessed too much of her parents' unhappy and abusive marriage. Ila Das and her sister Rima live on the brink of abject poverty because their brothers squandered the family fortune. Nanda Kaul felt trapped in her marriage to the Vice-Chancellor who never loved her, and he in turn felt compelled by his society to marry an Indian woman rather than Miss David, the Englishwoman he loved. These circumstances—like the demographics of their victims—vary widely. But together, they suggest that pain, trauma, and suffering are a part of all lives—rich and poor, male and female, young and old. And the book honestly examines the way that tragedy and trial can scar a person for life. Witnessing the chaotic dance at the Kasauli Club, Raka experiences a visceral flashback to her father's drunken binges, and she flees—thus showing readers some of the reasons she fears contact with others and longs to be left alone.

Uncomfortably, the book does not portray any of its characters triumphing over adversity or trauma, except perhaps Ram Lal's lucky escape from death by rabies. But by pointing to the commonplace nature of suffering, it suggests that no one is immune and that everyone can benefit from compassion and kindness. And, by revealing the inner lives—and suffering—of Nanda Kaul, Ila Das, and Raka, it gives readers a chance to cultivate their empathetic understanding ever further.



CLASS AND PRIVILEGE

Much of *Fire on the Mountain* centers on the lives of its privileged (or formerly privileged) trio of main characters. Nanda Kaul and Ila Das are coddled daughters of the Indian upper class that flourished under the British Raj. They lived on lovely estates with nannies, governesses, and tutors to tend to their needs. Nanda Kaul continued to live a privileged existence as the wife of a university Vice-Chancellor who made sure that his table was set with real silver and fine china and that his wife wore silk and jewels. Raka's family also has high class status because her father is a diplomat. But the book touches on the poverty and needs of the lower classes, too. When their brothers squander the family fortune, Rima and Ila Das become destitute. As a government welfare worker, Ila Das works and lives among poor and uneducated rural villagers, some of whom are so desperate that they're willing to marry their daughters off as child brides in exchange for more livestock.

High on her ridge, Nanda Kaul lives above the difficulty that traps Ila Das and her clients. But even in the depths of her

poverty, Ila clings to a sense of propriety instilled in her by her parents. She considers asking for begging, something she's too proud to do. She reflexively judges the villagers for their lack of education and considers the grainseller a brute because he belongs to a lower class than she once did—even though they are better off economically than she is. *Fire on the Mountain* only gestures toward India's caste system and history of British colonization. But it nevertheless explores some of the ways in which that history continued to mark 20th-century Indian society, and it critiques both how Nanda Kaul considers herself above difficulty and how the attitudes of people like Ila Das continue to perpetuate class-based distinctions despite social, economic, and cultural changes.



FEMALE OPPRESSION

Fire on the Mountain explores the inner lives of female characters, all of whom have been profoundly shaped by patriarchal society, which offers people like Nanda Kaul, Ila Das, Asha, Tara, and Raka limited opportunities and primarily values them for their marriageability. Impoverished villager Preet Singh treats his nine-year-old explicitly as a commodity when he arranges to marry her to a middle-aged man in exchange for some property and livestock. But the same logic rules the lives of wealthier women, too. Asha clearly learned at a young age that her worth derived from her beauty, and even though her children are grown, taking care of them is her primary purpose. The Vice-Chancellor valued the image of domestic comfort Nanda Kaul helped him maintain, but he didn't respect her enough to break off his affair with Miss David. Asha convinces Tara to stay with her abusive husband and considers herself heroic for her success.

Nanda Kaul and Raka both turn toward nature and isolation to escape the trap of social expectations and domestic responsibilities. But a zero-sum choice between having freedom or meaningful relationships doesn't make either of them happy. Ila Das and Rima escape the fate of oppressed wives but remain beholden to the brothers whose irresponsible choices threw them into extreme poverty. These tragic examples suggest that human flourishing requires a balance of autonomy and dependence that a rigidly patriarchal society fails to provide women. In the closing image of Raka setting fire to the Kasauli hills, the book metaphorically invokes the burning urgency of correcting this failure—and the potentially disastrous consequences of failing to do so.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



ANIMALS

The animals that roam the countryside around Carignano represent both freedom and chaos. On the one hand, they're unencumbered by human emotions or connections—at least those that remain wild, like the cuckoos at the **burned cottage**, the hoopoes in the eaves of the house, or the wild monkeys and jackals that live in the **ravine**. Caged animals, on the other hand, like the bears and leopards Nanda Kaul claims her father kept, stand for people imprisoned by convention and the stories they tell about themselves. Nanda Kaul herself relates to these animals, having long felt trapped and unfulfilled in life. Because she instinctively identifies with—and longs for—the kind of freedom wild animals possess, Raka becomes upset when the stories feature caged bears or leopards.

But the animals also represent the chaotic forces that shape a person's life without their input or control. The langur monkeys descend from the trees on unsuspecting homes, where they are capable of great destruction if no one stops them. The jackals in the ravine frustrate the attempts of the scientists and doctors at the Pasteur Institute to eradicate rabies precisely because they cannot be controlled. These animals shape the lives of the humans in their vicinity, just as the events that lie outside of a person's control—the illness of a parent, the loss of a family fortune, or the loneliness of being misunderstood and unappreciated, for instance—shape the lives of Raka, Ila Das, and Nanda Kaul.



BURNED COTTAGE

The burned cottage that lies a little way up the mountain from Carignano represents Raka. It went through the crucible of a wildfire, just as illness and the trauma of witnessing her father abuse her mother, Tara, have so tested Raka. The cottage is also isolated and solitary—its potential neighbors abandoned their plan to build when they saw the burned cottage's fate. Raka, meanwhile, likes nothing more than to be left alone and she spends most of her time by herself, resenting the few occasions on which Nanda Kaul imposes herself on her great-granddaughter.

Although Raka's visits to the burned cottage bring her momentary peace, the cottage's extreme isolation and emptiness is tragic, just as Raka's inability to connect with the people around her represents the tragic consequences of the trauma she's suffered. The burned cottage also suggests the ways in which true isolation begets a stasis that is impossible for living creatures to aspire to. The cottage is dead, empty, and frozen in time, while Raka and Nanda Kaul are living human beings who cannot survive in such a suspended state. In fact, Nanda Kaul's attempts to keep her life frozen ultimately end in tragedy. This suggests that if she is to persist and eventually thrive, Raka must eventually learn to cope with the personal

struggles she runs to isolation to avoid.



RAVINE

The ravine that lies below Carignano, cluttered with detritus, symbolizes the messiness and drama of life. It is a place populated by ghosts and ghouls. It is also a dangerous place, full of crumbling land, rabid **jackals**, and the biological waste of the Pasteur Institute. Early in the book, Nanda Kaul looks down at the clutter of trash, brambles, and rocks, and it reminds her of the house she shared with the Vice-Chancellor and their children—of all the demands and unhappiness that characterized that period of her life. Raka is drawn to the ravine, but she prefers to limit her explorations to its periphery. Her ability to explore the ravine daily but to return home with little more than a covering of dust and a few scrapes suggests how hard she's working to avoid entanglements with others. This makes sense, on one level, because there's a lot to fear in life: Ila Das can't escape her life of misery and suffering in the valley—life's messiness cannot be ignored or avoided entirely. But ultimately, no one can avoid life's chaos indefinitely. Unwilling to sacrifice her peace and solitude, Nanda Kaul holds her tongue against the urge to invite Ila Das to stay with her at Carignano. As Ila Das descends back toward her life of misery and trial in the valley, she's killed by Preet Singh, an angry villager. Summoned by a police officer to identify her friend's body, Nanda Kaul realizes that she, too, must descend the ridge into the valley below to confront the consequences of the choices that she—and others—made.

Related Characters: Asha (speaker), Nanda Kaul , Raka, Vice-Chancellor , Tara , Vina , Miss David

Related Themes:

Page Number: 15

Explanation and Analysis

Nanda Kaul's quiet, solitary life at Carignano is interrupted by apparently regular letters from her daughter Asha, who writes to Nanda Kaul to tell her about all the drama her own daughters, Tara and Vina, suffer. Tara's situation is especially dire: married to a cheating, abusive diplomat, she suffers frequent breakdowns of her mental and physical health. Her life thus serves as one of the novel's examples of the harms that can come to women in patriarchal societies in which they are considered and treated as less valuable than men. Nanda Kaul herself bears the wounds of a marriage less violent but not much less unhappy, since her husband didn't love her and carried on a lifelong affair with another woman.

But in this passage, it's clear that Tara's husband isn't the only person forcefully exerting sway over her actions: her mother is deeply involved in her life and marriage—evidently taking the side of her husband. In this way, the book shows how the problems of female oppression don't stem solely from individual acts of violence like the ones Tara's husband carries out, but also from the institutional and social pressures that organize society.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Random House India edition of *Fire on the Mountain* published in 2012.

Part 1, Chapter 4 Quotes

☞ In her last letter Asha had written, with her usual heartless blitheness, that she had persuaded Tara to try again. Tara's husband was given a new posting, this time in Geneva, and Asha had persuaded her daughter to go with him, to give him another chance. There was the little problem of their child who was only just recovering from a near-fatal attack of typhoid, but Asha was sure they would find a way to deal with this minor problem. The main thing, she had trumpeted, was for Tara to rouse herself and make another try at being a successful diplomat's wife. Surely Geneva would be an excellent place for such an effort. "Why, why shouldn't she be happy?" Asha had written and Nanda Kaul had not replied, had been too disgusted to reply.

Part 1, Chapter 5 Quotes

☞ Getting up at last, she went slowly round to the back of the house and leant on the wooden railing on which the yellow rose creeper had blossomed so youthfully last month but was now reduced to an exhausted mass of grey creaks and groans again. She gazed down into the gorge with its gashes of red earth, its rocks and gullies and sharply spiked agaves [...] and said Is it wrong? Have I not done enough and had enough? I want no more. I want nothing. Can I not be left with nothing? But there was no answer and of course she expected none.

Looking down, over all those years she had survived and borne, she saw them, not bare and shining as the plains below, but like the gorge, cluttered, choked and blackened with the heads of children and grandchildren, servants and guests, all restlessly surging, clamouring about her.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Raka, Vice-Chancellor

Related Themes:

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 18-19

Explanation and Analysis

Just after reading the letter informing her of her great-granddaughter Raka's imminent arrival, Nanda Kaul paces around her garden in agitation. Behind the house lies a deep ravine that is choked with trash and underbrush. This passage describes the ravine through Nanda Kaul's eyes. To get there, she passes by a creeping rosebush planted by previous owners of the house. It blooms exuberantly in the spring, but by early summer, its blooms have died, and it has become dusty and dry. In this context, then, it figuratively suggests the passage of life and implies that Nanda Kaul has gone beyond the blooming period of life and into the dusty retreat of old age.

At first, this image suggests that Nanda Kaul's distress focuses on her old age, but her thoughts as she looks down into the gorge are on the years that most people would associate with the blooming rose: the youth during which she was married to the Vice-Chancellor and raising their children. Nanda Kaul makes it plain to readers that this period of her life wasn't something she enjoyed or found beautiful. Instead, it was a trial for her. When she looks down into the gorge and sees the heads of her children, she implies that they were as good as garbage to her. This is a harsh attitude and unexpected attitude for a mother to take, and it raises the question of what happened to make her feel this way. The answers—centering around the limitations Nanda Kaul feels were imposed on her by her gender and her class—will only come to light as the summer unfolds.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Raka, Vice-Chancellor

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 25-26

Explanation and Analysis

During the hottest part of the day, Nanda Kaul rests in her bedroom. She finds the stillness hardly easier to manage as an old woman than she did as a young woman with countless responsibilities, a period she considers in this passage. The contrast between the endless motion and pressure conveyed in this passage and the quiet and repose of Carignano in the book's early chapters gives context to her concerns about Raka's visit. But, on closer inspection, this passage also showcases some of the ways in which Nanda Kaul struggles to be fully honest with herself.

Nanda Kaul resents Raka's arrival because she associates isolation with freedom. Yet, this passage makes a clear distinction between the two. In this memory, she is isolated in her room, but she is not free from others. She cannot stop focusing on the external world or feeling the weight of the roles assigned to her, whether she wanted them or not. But the degree of pressure she feels to respond extends beyond gendered expectations of motherhood. Indeed, she and the Vice-Chancellor are wealthy enough to afford servants and caregivers who can relieve her of some of that responsibility. Yet, a part of her still reaches out to the world beyond the walls of her room. She wants to be still and free, but neither of these things come naturally to her. She admits that, for her, this is a skill to be acquired, not a natural state. But she does not yet grasp the implications of that admission and continues to tell herself that her nature is something other than what it truly is.

Part 1, Chapter 7 Quotes

☹☹ She had practised this stillness, this composure, for years, for an hour every afternoon: it was an art, not easily acquired. The most difficult had been those years in that busy house where doors were never shut [...] She remembered how [...] she had spent the sleepless hour making out the direction from which a shout came, or a burst of giggles, an ominous growling from the dogs, a contest of squirrels under the guavas in the orchard [...] All was subdued, but nothing was ever still. [...] This would go on for an hour and she would keep her eyes tightly clenched, her hands folded on her chest [...] determinedly not responding. The effort to not respond would grow longer by the minute, heavier, more unendurable, till at last it was sitting on her chest, grasping her by the neck. At four o'clock she would break out from under it with a gasp.

☹☹ Walking faster and faster back and forth, back and forth over the lawn, she had stayed out till she heard the car [...] turn in at the gate [...] Lights off, silence, then the throwing open of the car door, and her husband had come out. He had been to drop some of the guests home—no, she corrected herself with asperity, *one* of the guests home. She watched him go up the veranda steps, puffing at his cigar [...] She had not moved, not made a sound. She watched him cross the veranda, go into the drawing room, and waited till the light there went out and another came on in the bedroom that had been only a small dressing-room until she had had his bed put there. Then she paced the lawn again, slower and slower. [...] That was one time she had been alone: a moment of private triumph, cold and proud.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Vice-Chancellor , Miss David

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 27-28

Explanation and Analysis

During her afternoon rest, Nanda Kaul searches her memory for a time that she was alone during her marriage, and she comes up with this. This memory describes the aftermath of a party and her anxious wait for her husband to come home. It strongly hints that he is carrying on an affair with one of their guests, although this truth is so painful that Nanda Kaul can't bring herself to think about it directly until much later in the book, when Ila Das invokes the mistress's name—Miss David—directly. But even without that full context, this passage makes it clear that something has gone seriously awry in the marriage, from Nanda Kaul's focus on the one guest to the hint that she has made her husband start sleeping in his own room.

Nanda Kaul's sense of betrayal in this moment highlights the limitations imposed on her by the feminine roles she was expected to play. It's clear that she's exercised the options she has and that they're limited—moving her husband to another room clearly hasn't made him drop his mistress. But it also betrays her constant assertions in the first half of the book that she's happier alone. She calls this a moment of triumph because it was a moment of solitude, yet the atmosphere is anything but triumphant. Indeed, it is tragic. The book gives readers an early hint here that Nanda Kaul's oft-repeated love of solitude may not be genuine but rather an attempt to claim ownership of a situation forced on her by others. She tries to make her isolation more palatable by pretending to herself that she's chosen it willingly rather than having it forced upon her. But that lie requires effort—and a very careful, controlled relationship with her memories—to maintain.

Part 1, Chapter 8 Quotes

☹️ Seated on the veranda in the late afternoon shade, Nanda Kaul waved away the tea tray and read, in small sips, bits and pieces from *The Pillow Book of Sei Shonagon*.

'When A Woman Lives Alone' was the title of one scrap that caught her eye:

"When a woman lives alone, her house should be extremely dilapidated, the mud wall should be falling to pieces, and if there is a pond, it should be overgrown with water plants. It is not essential that the garden be covered with sage brush, but weeds should be growing through the sand in patches, for this gives the place a poignantly desolate look.

I greatly dislike a woman's house when it is clear she has scurried about with a knowing look on her face, arranging everything just as it should be, and when the gate is kept tightly shut."

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Raka, Ila Das

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 29

Explanation and Analysis

Late in the afternoon of the day that brought news of her great-granddaughter's imminent arrival, Nanda Kaul has her tea while reading a book from her collection. *The Pillow Book of Sei Shonagon* was written by a medieval Japanese noblewoman who lived and served in the court of the empress. The fact that Nanda Kaul is reading a fairly obscure book suggests her intelligence and cultivated tastes. Of course, the passage quoted here appeals to her because it reflects the life she lives and wants to maintain: that of a woman alone.

Nanda Kaul loves and re-reads this passage multiple times before going on to tell herself that Sei Shonagon would likely have approved of her home and her life at Carignano, even though it's clear from this passage that Carignano is the exact opposite of what Shonagon finds charming in this passage. Carignano is well-kept and orderly, and Nanda Kaul is the woman who scurries about arranging things. And she's already made it clear that she would very much like to keep her gate shut to everyone, be they family members (Raka), old friends (Ila Das), or mailmen. The burned cottage up the hill more closely matches the house Shonagon describes. This in turn should put readers on the alert for the lies that Nanda Kaul tells herself and others. She wants freedom but doesn't want to accept the costs associated with it. Freedom from social conventions and expectations is also freedom from rules and order; as Raka will soon

demonstrate, it is messy, chaotic, and sometimes dangerous. It is overrun and a little ramshackle, like the house Shonagon describes here, though it has its charms. This passage warns Nanda Kaul that she can't have both freedom and control, although she doesn't hear it.

a caring woman who found that part of her false only when her love and care was abused by others like the children who obviously never bothered to try to know or understand their mother as an individual human being, or the husband who never loved her.

Part 1, Chapter 9 Quotes

☛☛ The care of others was a habit Nanda Kaul had mislaid. It had been a religious calling she had believed in till she found it fake. It had been a vocation that one day went dull and drought-struck as though its life-spring had dried up.

It had happened on her first day alone at Carignano. After her husband's death, her sons and daughters had come to help her empty the Vice-Chancellor's house, pack and crate their belongings and distribute them, then escort her to Kasauli. For a while, they had stood about, in Carignano, like too much furniture. She had wondered what to do with them.

Fortunately, they had gone away. Brought up by her to be busy and responsible, they all had families and employments to tend. None could stay with her. When they left, she paced the house, proprietorially, feeling the feel of each stone in the paving with bare feet.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Vice-Chancellor

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 33

Explanation and Analysis

As she considers the chaos and upheaval—the overwhelming and unending responsibilities that characterized her married life—Nanda Kaul comes to this conclusion about herself: once, she cared for others, but she lost the ability to do so when she left that life behind. The idea that she no longer feels it necessary to take care of others fits nicely with other things she tells herself: that freedom is to be found in isolation, and that she is utterly contented with her solitary life. But here again, Nanda Kaul's own thoughts illustrate an unacknowledged tension in her beliefs.

She describes caregiving first as a religion and a vocation, words that suggest external rules and expectations. So, at the beginning of this passage, it's possible to see Nanda Kaul further implicating the limited roles assigned to women as the primary source of her misery. But then she describes caregiving as a "life-spring," an image that suggests something internal and intrinsic to her character. This, in turn, opens the possibility that Nanda Kaul is, in fact,

Part 2, Chapter 1 Quotes

☛☛ Commotion preceded her like a band of langurs. Only it took the form of schoolboys who were unfortunately let out from school at just the same time as Ila das was proceeding toward Carignano with her uneven, rushing step, in her ancient white court shoes, prodding the tip of her great brown umbrella into the dust with an air of faked determination. Like langurs, the boys swung about her, long-armed, careless, insulting. They hooted at her little grey topknot that wobbled on top of her head, at her spectacles that slipped down to the tip of her nose and were only prevented from falling off by an ancient purple ribbon looped over her ears, at the grey rag of the petticoat that gaped dismally beneath the lace hem of her sari—at everything, in short, that was Ila Das. [...] She said only harmless things like "I'll tell your teacher—I know your Principal [...]"

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Ila Das

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 117-118

Explanation and Analysis

On the appointed day, Ila Das makes the trek up the side of the mountain to Carignano. From the safety of the garden, Nanda Kaul, Raka, and Ram Lal watch as unruly little boys harass the unfortunate woman. Crucially, this passage introduces Ila Das to readers through the eyes of Nanda Kaul and Raka. And in their eyes, Ila Das is a sight to behold. She isn't just surrounded by commotion but seems to *be* commotion itself. The way the boys mob her suggests how pathetic a figure she cuts: they know that she won't be able to defend herself. The hard work and poverty she's endured make themselves apparent in her ragged clothes and unkempt appearance. And her desperate attempts to cling to her dignity, to threaten the boys into submission, only add to the pathos of the scene. Although Nanda Kaul has treated this visit like a barely endurable trial and although the boys treat Ila Das as a nuisance, the book works to cultivate readers' empathy and reminds them that no one deserves to be treated this way.

Importantly, the book associates the schoolboys with langurs in this scene. Thus far, while animals have represented the chaos and uncontrollable nature of life, that chaos has stayed firmly rooted in the animal world. Only now, as Ila Das symbolically and literally bears the cares of the world up the hill to Carignano, does the chaos of the animal world become closely associated with human society. And the fact that these boys dare to disrespect an elderly woman in this way further implicates the sexist attitudes that the book criticizes.

the effort it has always required to separate herself from the concerns and needs of others. For her, solitude is a skill to be practiced and attained, whereas for Raka, it is simply a state of being. She has what Nanda Kaul thinks she wants—but when Nanda Kaul is confronted with the reality of Raka's existence, it makes her uncomfortable. In turn, this suggests the degree to which Nanda Kaul isn't being fully honest with herself—or with readers—about her motivations and desires, and how challenging and uncomfortable it is for her to try to maintain her own fictions.

Part 2, Chapter 4 Quotes

☹☹ But Raka ignored her. She ignored her so calmly, so totally that it made Nanda Kaul breathless. She eyed the child with apprehension now, wondering at this total rejection, so natural, instinctive and effortless when compared with her own planned and willful rejection of the child.

Seeing Raka bend her head to study a pine cone in her fist, the eyelids drooping down like two mauve shells and the short hair settled like a dusty cap about her scalp, Nanda Kaul saw that she was the finished, perfected model of what Nanda Kaul herself was—merely a brave, flawed experiment.

[...] Like an insect burrowing through the sandy loam and pine needles of the hillsides, like her own great-grandmother, Raka wanted only one thing—to be left alone and pursue her own secret life amongst the rocks and pines of Kasauli.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Raka

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 52

Explanation and Analysis

Very soon after Raka arrives, Nanda Kaul begins to realize that the little girl neither wants nor really needs her great-grandmother's attention. This passage places readers in Nanda Kaul's perspective and paints a portrait of the little girl that shows how deeply unsettling Nanda Kaul finds her. As much as Nanda Kaul bemoaned the idea of having to care for Raka (or anyone else) earlier in the novel, at this point, it's clear that she actually wants to be involved in the girl's life and finds it unsettling to be denied.

This passage also describes Raka's complete and total sense of independence. Nanda Kaul can see that Raka neither needs nor wants anyone else to complete her. She is, as Nanda Kaul acknowledges to herself in this passage, the kind of independent soul that Nanda Kaul wishes she herself could be. In an earlier chapter, Nanda Kaul described

Part 2, Chapter 5 Quotes

☹☹ The refuse that the folds of the gorge held and slowly ate and digested was of interest too. There were splotches of blood, there were yellow stains oozing through paper, there were bones and the mealy ashes of bones. Tins of Tulip ham and Kissan jam. Broken china, burnt kettles, rubber tyres and bent wheels.

Once she came upon a great, thick yellow snake poured in rings upon itself, basking on the sunned top of a flat rock. She watched it for a long while, digging her toes into the slipping red soil, keeping still the long wand of broom she held in her hand. She had seen the tips of snakes' tails parting the cracks of rocks, she had seen slit eyes watching her from grottoes of shade, but she had never seen the whole creature before.

Related Characters: Raka

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 53-54

Explanation and Analysis

Not long after she arrives at Carignano, Raka discovers the fascinating and dangerous ravine that falls away from one side of the property. Unlike her great-grandmother, Nanda Kaul, Raka is a truly independent person by both temperament and habit. She feels the least comfortable around people and the most comfortable in total solitude and isolation. Nanda Kaul envies Raka's sense of freedom because she wishes to feel free after a lifetime of taking care of others' needs. She associates isolation with freedom and goes to great lengths to keep friends and family at bay. But she isn't truly alone: her servant, Ram Lal takes care of her needs for her.

In this passage, it becomes clear that freedom—real

freedom—is messy and dangerous, too. The ravine is full of unwanted and discarded things. Raka is unwanted and discarded by her parents—a distant and uncaring father and a mother too mentally and physically ill to care for her daughter. She has the freedom to explore on her own, but she also has no one to protect her from the dangers hinted at by the blood and bones scattered liberally across the landscape. The snake becomes an object of fascination for Raka because it is like her. Both girl and animal are happier (and safer) when allowed to keep to themselves and unbothered by the interference and expectations of others.

Part 2, Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ “You should go in the evening, at the proper time,” he said primly, suddenly recalling better days, spent in service of richer, better homes. “You should have an ayah. Then she could wash you and dress you in clean clothes at four o’clock and take you down to the club. You would meet nice babas there. They come in the evenings with their ayahs. They play on the swings and their parents play bridge and tennis. Then they have lemonade and Vitmo in the garden. That is what you should do,” he told her, severely.

Raka listened to him create this bright picture of hill-station club life politely rather than curiously. It was a life she had observed from the outside—in Delhi, in Manila, in Madrid—but had never tried to enter. She had always seemed to lack the ticket. “Hmm,” she said, picking at a nicely crusty scab on her elbow.

Related Characters: Ram Lal (speaker), Raka

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 57

Explanation and Analysis

After one of Raka’s daily forays into the ravine, she discusses what she discovered—including a large, yellow rat snake—with Ram Lal. He warns her to be careful, laments her choice of activities, and in this passage suggests what he thinks is more appropriate. Ram Lal tells Raka that she should be spending her evenings playing at the Kasauli Club with the children of other privileged families. On one level, this passage comments on the nature of freedom. Raka is free not just because she is isolated, almost completely cut off from the world of social obligations, but because she knows herself. She doesn’t want to participate in the games

Ram Lal describes. She doesn’t know how to. She chooses the ravine because it suits her better, and at Carignano, no one forces her into the uncomfortable social interactions she abhors.

However, this passage also seems to comment on the changes in Indian society in the second half of the 20th century, after the end of the British Raj. The country club and its games evoke European culture—the Kasauli Club isn’t that different to clubs Raka has attended in Madrid, Spain and elsewhere. But the British left India in 1947, so it’s notable that the privileged classes maintain their customs. In the wild, untamable person of Raka, the book suggests that modern India must find its own path forward on its own terms, rather than slavishly preserving the past.

Part 2, Chapter 9 Quotes

☞ Bending down so that her face was at a level with the hunched child’s and her nose tapered softly forward, she said, “Raka, you really *are* a great-grandchild of mine, aren’t you? You are more like me than *any* of my children or grandchildren. You are *exactly* like me, Raka.”

But Raka retreated pell-mell from this outspoken advance. It was too blatant, too obvious for her who loved secrecy above all. Her small face blanched as she pinched her lips together in distaste.

Nanda Kaul was equally shocked. Quickly straightening her back, she sat in her chair, stiffly. By the manner in which she tensed herself and drew strict lines down her face and folded her hands in her lap stilly, it was clear that she was trying to repair her authority, her composure, her distance in age.

They averted their faces from each other.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul (speaker), Raka

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 71

Explanation and Analysis

Not long after her unsuccessful attempt to connect with Raka by joining her on a walk, Nanda Kaul quizzes her over her odd choices one afternoon at tea. She wants to know why Raka never asks to go to the Kasauli Club or anywhere else. Raka retorts that her great-grandmother doesn’t go to the club either. In this passage, Nanda Kaul responds by remarking on the similarities between herself and her granddaughter.

But in trying to claim their similarity, Nanda Kaul

inadvertently proves their difference. Raka is exactly the kind of person Nanda Kaul wants to be, but that isn't how she is. Raka doesn't need anyone to approve of—or even notice—her solitude or anything else about her. She doesn't need a companion in her solitude and freedom. Nanda Kaul not only wants companionship, but she needs her solitude to be witnessed and appreciated by others to feel like it's valuable. She doesn't truly want to give up her solitude, even though having authority requires the presence of other people to whom one can act authoritatively, which is why it's incompatible with isolation and solitude. Moreover, although Nanda Kaul thinks that isolation is freedom and that solitude will bring her happiness, she clearly still wants to make an emotional connection with Raka. Finally, saying that she and Raka are alike does not *make* them alike. Raka's immediate retreat drives this point home to readers and to Nanda Kaul, whose wounded reaction shows that she understands Raka's rejection even if she doesn't like it.

make sense of the costumes donned by the partygoers, because their barely controlled exuberance and excessive drinking are too familiar, as they're similar to the experiences she's had throughout her young life with her father.

Although readers become aware of the problems in Tara's marriage early in the novel, through Asha's letters to Nanda Kaul, this is the first—and only—time they are shown what Tara suffers in such a personal and visceral way. This scene drives home the book's assertions that a society in which females are subject to male expectations, authority, and abuse, is a society full of danger and violence. And seeing a glimpse of what Raka has witnessed and been shaped by provides insight into her character. Growing up in such a profoundly unstable household, it makes sense that she would spurn human contact as much as possible. Thus far, the adults in her life have been either untrustworthy and violent or incapable of protecting her.

Part 2, Chapter 11 Quotes

☛☛ Somewhere behind them, behind it all, was her father, home from a party, stumbling and crashing through the curtains of night, his mouth opening to let out a flood of rotten stench, beating at her mother with hammers and fists of abuse—harsh, filthy abuse that made Raka cower under her bedclothes and wet the mattress in fright, feeling the stream of urine warm and weakening between her legs like a stream of blood, and her mother lay down on the floor and shut her eyes and wept. Under her feet, in the dark, Raka felt that flat, wet jelly of her mother's being squelching and quivering, so that she didn't know where to put her feet and wept as she tried to get free of it. Ahead of her, no longer on the ground but at some distance now, her mother was crying. Then it was a jackal crying.

Related Characters: Raka, Ram Lal, Tara

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 78-79

Explanation and Analysis

After Ram Lal describes the Kasauli Club's summer dance, Raka sneaks from her bedroom late at night to check it out for herself. But the fairytale image Ram Lal described is obliterated by the reality, because the modern Kasauli Club summer dance features a gaggle of drunken adults in masquerade costumes whirling around the dance floor. Terror floods through Raka as she watches and tries to

Part 2, Chapter 14 Quotes

☛☛ But it gave her an increased sense of Raka's dependence on her, Nanda Kaul. She was not sure if it was poignant, ironical or merely irritating that Raka herself remained totally unaware of her dependence, was indeed as independent and solitary as ever. Watching her wandering amongst the rocks and agaves of the ravine, tossing a horse chestnut rhythmically from hand to hand, Nanda Kaul wondered if she at all realized how solitary she was. She was the only child Nanda Kaul had ever known who preferred to stand apart and go off and disappear to being loved, cared for and made the center of attention. The children Nanda Kaul had known had wanted only to be such centres: Raka alone did not.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul, Raka, Vice-Chancellor, Tara

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 87

Explanation and Analysis

Partway through the summer, Nanda Kaul gets a letter saying that Raka needs to stay longer because Tara's health has taken a turn for the worse. In this passage, Nanda Kaul muses on the implications of this news. It's notable that Nanda Kaul takes this news so well, when the very idea of Raka coming in the first place was so upsetting to her. In part, this speaks to her fascination with the little girl, her desire to understand what animates Raka. But it also hints that she is, perhaps, not as inclined toward the solitary life

as she claims. While it's clear that she still resents the demands made on her by her own children, part of what frustrates Nanda Kaul about Raka is that Nanda Kaul *wants* to love and care for her and make her the center of attention. This, in turn, suggests that her negative experiences of motherhood may have more to do with the expectations and demands attached to that role by her society and her former husband.

Readers should also note the way this passage emphasizes another essential difference between Nanda Kaul and Raka yet again. Nanda Kaul spends time thinking about and crafting the image of herself she wishes to embody, but Raka is entirely unselfconscious. She is who she is, and her actions and preferences flow from that. She doesn't pretend to be something she isn't. And that is what makes her so fascinating to Nanda Kaul: Raka lives her truth honestly, and that is what gives her freedom.

Part 2, Chapter 16 Quotes

☝☝ Going down into the garden, Nanda Kaul said, in a voice that was incredibly altered, that was hoarse with a true remembrance, "How funny, Raka, I just remembered how your mother, when she visited me here as a little girl, used to sing 'Rainy days are lily days! Rainy days are lily days!'"

"Lily days?" said Raka, puzzled. "What did she mean?"

"You'll see," Nanda Kaul said, and her face twisted oddly at the thought of the blue letter folded up inside her desk. "Go now, go for your walk," she said, harshly.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Raka (speaker), Father , Tara

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 95-96

Explanation and Analysis

One afternoon, a rainstorm drives Nanda Kaul and Raka inside at teatime, during which Nanda Kaul tells Raka fabulous stories about her own father's travels in Tibet. When the storm passes, the two go outside, where another memory descends on Nanda Kaul. Notably, this storm happens in the wake of Nanda Kaul receiving news that Raka must stay at Carignano longer, because her mother Tara is sick again.

The book draws a clear distinction between the tone Nanda Kaul used to tell the stories about her father and the way her voice sounds now. The former is more like the tour-guide voice she employed—much to Raka's annoyance—on a

walk to Monkey Point. It is associated with Nanda Kaul trying too hard to capture Raka's interest, and it implies a falseness either in what she's saying or how she's pretending to feel. In this passage, her voice is husky with a true memory. And it becomes clear that, contrary to her prior assertions, she can in fact call up some memories of Tara to distinguish her from the great horde of her children and grandchildren. But doing so shows that she found at least one thing about Tara's visit charming rather than degrading—and undermines her belief that she can only be free if she is completely alone. It's not necessarily caregiving itself that upsets Nanda Kaul, it's the expectation and the scope of her responsibilities in the past that she resents.

Part 2, Chapter 17 Quotes

☝☝ In the silence that followed, Nanda Kaul bitterly cursed her failure to comfort children, her total inability to place herself in another's position and act accordingly. Fantasy and fairy tales had their place in life, she knew it so well. Why then did she tell the child the truth? Who wanted truth? Who could stand it? Nobody. Not even herself. So how could Raka?

But Raka did not say anything more. Her face was pale, but composed. She might have been indifferent, although deliberately so. After all, she had known her mother ill for most of her life, mysteriously ill, mostly in bed, under a loose pink blanket that smelled of damp, like the lilies. It was no new shock. Her voice had something flat about it, Nanda Kaul noted, when she got up, saying "I think I'll go out now, Nani."

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Raka, Tara

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 97

Explanation and Analysis

The morning after the rainstorm, Raka asks Nanda Kaul about the letter she received from Asha a few days earlier. Nanda Kaul has, up to this moment, believed that knowledge to be her secret. She initially relished the sweet sensation that Raka needed her (even if Raka didn't know it) and when she remembered that Tara was a human being at the end of the last chapter, she felt momentarily guilty for hiding information from Raka and for deriving pleasure from another's suffering. But now, it seems that Raka knew all along. Or perhaps, the book suggests, she has guessed based on the familiar pattern of her mother's illnesses and breakdowns.

It's clear that the news affects Raka. Readers know that she

does have feelings from the memories that flashed before her eyes when she snuck into the Kasauli Club's summer dance. And she will leave the table for the burned cottage, the loneliest place on the mountain, to compose herself. But notably, the "failure" Nanda Kaul frets over in this passage exists only in her head. It comes from her socialized beliefs about how she should behave or what she and others should do and feel—the same beliefs that guided her during the unhappy hours of her marriage and childrearing. Readers know—and Nanda Kaul suspects—that Raka is a deeply traumatized individual. But her situation doesn't demand the usual solutions. Instead, this moment offers Nanda Kaul an opportunity to meet Raka where she is as a unique individual. Part of the book's great tragedy is that she cannot escape the prison of her own expectations enough to do this.

Part 2, Chapter 18 Quotes

☛ It was the ravaged, destroyed and barren spaces in Kasauli that drew her: the ravine where yellow snakes slept under grey rocks and agaves growing out of the dust and rubble, the skeletal pines that rattled in the wind, the wind-levelled hilltops and the seared remains of the safe, cozy, civilized world in which Raka had no part and to which she owed no attachment. Here she stood, in the blackened shell of a house that the next storm would bring down, looking down the ravine to the tawny plains [...] She raised herself on to the tips of her toes—tall, tall as a pine—stretched out her arms till she felt the yellow light strike a spark down her fingertips and along her arms till she was alight, ablaze.

Then she broke loose, raced out on to the hillside, up the ridge, through the pines, in blazing silence.

Related Characters: Raka, Tara

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols:   

Page Number: 99-100

Explanation and Analysis

After learning of her mother's most recent illness, Raka flees Carignano for the shell of the burned cottage that sits farther up the mountain. In the context of the news about Tara, the book clearly insinuates that much of Raka's drive toward isolation is, in fact, a response to the trauma she's suffered. But this passage contains hints that something of the wild is inherent to her character, too: she has never felt

at home in the cozy world of civilization. Like the moon that is her namesake, she floats far above the concerns and affairs of the people around her, untouched and unbothered by almost everything that passes between them.

Her attraction to the burned cottage arises from the similarities between the two. The cottage represents civilization and society, all the rules and expectations that govern life among humans. It was safe and cozy, at least until the wildfire appeared and showed the emptiness of civilization, its inability to protect people from chaos and destruction. Like the house, Raka has been devastated by the trauma of witnessing her parents' marriage. And like the fire that burned it, she rejects the rules meant to keep people in line. The second half of this passage sees Raka basking in the warmth of the sun, but in such a way that she becomes the wildfire herself, sparking heat from her fingertips and racing up the mountain. This both emphasizes her rejection of civilization and foreshadows the momentous decisions she will make in the book's final chapters.

Part 2, Chapter 19 Quotes

☛ "Oh yes, all my father's animals lived inside. I really believe he cared for them as much as for us. Even the pangolin. You wouldn't think anyone could be attached to that hard, scaly creature, always curled up inside its armour, but somehow my father was. He admired it, you see—he admired anything uncommon, extraordinary..."

As she murmured on, touching the knives and forks on the table, her eyes wandering in a kind of grey thicket of dreams, the child squirmed, looked over her shoulder at the window, at the sun glistening on the knoll, the pine boughs dipping as the parrots sprang on them, screaming, and longed to get away. She could not understand this new talkativeness of her great-grandmother's who had preferred, till lately, not to talk to her at all, nor had wanted to be talked to. Now she was unable to stop.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul (speaker), Raka, Father

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 106

Explanation and Analysis

In an attempt to capture and hold Raka's attention, Nanda Kaul begins telling stories about her childhood at teatime, including ones about the wild animals her father kept in

cages. In this passage, Nanda Kaul makes a clear connection between the wild animals and “us”—she and her father’s other children. Aligning herself with a trapped wild animal in this way harkens back to the way she felt trapped by the roles of wife and mother when the Vice-Chancellor was still alive. Metaphorically, Nanda Kaul’s story here evokes the way a patriarchal society cages females, trapping them in specific roles and limiting their autonomy.

But astute readers might also catch glimpses of Nanda Kaul’s subconscious truths in the story, too. The way she describes her father’s pangolin—a small, scaly, ant-eating mammal—sounds like how a person might describe the remarkable, mysterious, and hardened Raka. Nanda Kaul loves the tough and scaly Raka. And although she wishes to understand her, it’s clear that she never will. Thus, her description of her father’s feelings for his pet represents her relationship with Raka.

Finally, just as the book gestures toward the ways in which Nanda Kaul felt trapped by the expectations of the men in her life (both her father and the Vice-Chancellor she married), in this moment, she takes on their role, caging the wild Raka within the bars of her story and her overwhelming need to love and be loved. Like the pangolin and like Nanda Kaul before her, Raka becomes desperate to escape.

Part 2, Chapter 20 Quotes

☛ But now Raka sighed and twisted aside to see if Ram Lal would not come and release her from this disagreeable intimacy. He did not come. She would have to do something. She would have to break out into freedom again. She could not bear to be confined to the old lady’s fantasy world when the reality outside appealed so strongly.

She thought desperately, with longing, of the charred house on the ridge, of the fire-blasted hilltop where nothing sounded, mercifully, but the creaking of the pines in the wind and the demented cuckoos, wildly calling.

And here she was, hedged, smothered, stifled inside the old lady’s words, dreams and more words. She yawned with boredom.

“You are tired,” said Nanda Kaul, sadly.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul (speaker), Raka

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 109-110

Explanation and Analysis

Late one evening, after Raka returns from her daily explorations, Nanda Kaul meets her in the garden, where she insists on telling the little girl more stories about her past. This time, they focus on the years of her marriage to the Vice-Chancellor, specifically the way he spoiled their children with pets, riding lessons, and a badminton court. The badminton court already featured prominently in another memory that clearly brings Nanda Kaul pain, suggesting here that she’s not being totally honest with herself. And indeed, Raka intuitively senses Nanda Kaul’s dishonesty with herself, sees the way her great-grandmother wants to use her stories to make her past more interesting and less painful. The book places a strong emphasis on the value of self-knowledge and honesty, claiming that painful realities are preferable to pretty fantasies. Raka sees this, but Nanda Kaul cannot.

In this moment, Nanda Kaul forces Raka to do something she knows the child hates: to remain in the presence of another person for an extended period of time and to participate in the revision of history. Notably, Nanda Kaul thinks back on her earlier life with resentment for the way her husband—and, more broadly, their community and broader society—expected her to perform the roles of wife, mother, and hostess. Now the roles are reversed, with Nanda Kaul playing the part of the peevish, attention-hungry child and Raka filling in as the impatient, trapped parent.

Part 3, Chapter 3 Quotes

☛ Suddenly Ila Das gave the crooked umbrella a merry swing—a swing that belonged to a park on a Sunday afternoon, when the band played, the merry-go-round revolved and flowers sprang to attention in their beds all around—and gave a little hop, then clutched Nanda Kaul’s arm in its long sleeve of silk that buttoned at the wrist with two opals, and said, “Ooh, look, those lovely apricot trees. Did they bear a good crop, Nanda? Did you make that delicious jam? Mmm, when I think of it...” A naughty pink tongue crept over the lips, licking, then departed with a giggle. “How lovely the house looks, Nanda. *Dear Carignano*. Now if you were to see *my* castle...” and she went into peals of laughter that rang like a fire engine’s fatal bell so that two doves, amazed shot out of the trees and vanished, and even Raka took a startled step backwards.

Related Characters: Ila Das (speaker), Nanda Kaul, Raka

Related Themes: **Page Number:** 124**Explanation and Analysis**

When she finally reaches Carignano, Ila Das enthusiastically greets her old friend Nanda Kaul. As Nanda Kaul leads Ila Das toward the veranda, Ila keeps up a steady stream of patter. This passage occurs just as she catches sight of the house and the apricot trees. While she expresses admiration (and a little jealousy) for the beauty and peace in which Nanda Kaul lives, this passage is primarily notable for the way Ila Das puts on an unflattering and unconvincing performance of carefree youthfulness. Like Nanda Kaul, she's pretending to be something that she's not, lying to herself to try to make her current circumstances seem less unbearable. Nanda Kaul is lonely, so she tells herself not only that she doesn't need others, but that she resents any and all relationships with her family and friends. Ila Das is destitute, old, and careworn. Yet here, she acts like a carefree little girl.

Notably, readers see Ila Das through Raka's eyes primarily in this passage—she stands watching with rapt fascination as Ila Das approaches the house. Because she's been so strongly associated with the freedom and independence of animals thus far in the book, it's not surprising when her reaction mirrors the startled doves who fly from the trees. Unfortunately for Raka, she's bound, at least for the moment, by her great-grandmother's manners and cannot run away, too, although it's clear that she'd like to. One of Raka's purposes in the story is to illustrate how much better it is to look at the world honestly than to make up soothing lies about it. And on this count, Ila Das's self-deception looks particularly unattractive through Raka's eyes.

Part 3, Chapter 4 Quotes

☛☛ Raka wilted. She hung her arms between her knees and drooped her head on its thin stalk. It seemed the old ladies were going to play, all afternoon, that game of old age—that reconstructing, block by gilded block, of the castle of childhood, so ramshackle and precarious, and of stuffing it with that dolls' house furniture, those impossibly gilded red velvet sofas and painted bedsteads, that always smelt of dust and mice and that she had never cared to play with. She very much wanted to eat her tea, for once to have something to eat at tea, but it seemed she would have to pay for it. She gazed at a small ant under the table, crawling off with a crystal of sugar loaded on to its back, and sighed.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Raka, Ila Das**Related Themes:**  **Page Number:** 127-128**Explanation and Analysis**

As soon as she sits down at Nanda Kaul's tea table, Ila Das launches into reminiscences about her and Nanda's childhoods. She describes the beautiful estate on which Nanda Kaul grew up and talks about spending lovely afternoons there, drinking tea in the garden with Nanda Kaul, her siblings, and their mother. Raka hates this kind of talk for the reasons outlined in this passage.

Raka's feelings say something about her own childhood. Readers already know that she has frequently been ill, that her parents' marriage is a traumatizing mess, and that she has few social skills and no friends. So, her antipathy might in fact be a way to avoid looking at these painful truths. But in general, the book sides with Raka in condemning the way that Ila Das gilds the lilies of her memory here, the way that she burnishes the past to make it seem better than it was, and then uses her memories to escape facing the pain and suffering of her current life. There's nothing wrong with memory itself, but the lies and exaggerations make the memories Ila Das shares cheap. It would be much better, the book suggests, for her to be truthful than effusive.

Part 3, Chapter 5 Quotes

☛☛ Nanda Kaul sat back in her upright chair and gazed straight at [Ila Das], in silence. She was not going to help Ila Das play this game. No, it was too shameful. She had decided that it was shameful and that, in any case, it had no appeal for Raka, the child who never played games.

"But the summers were best," Ila Das burred on. "In spite of the heat and dust, summers were best. Those enormous melons that grew in your garden—the children would split them and eat them on the veranda steps. The lichee trees would be loaded, oh *loaded*, with bunches of ripe pink fruit. And the jamun tree—mum, mum," she gobbled. "And after the heat of the day, the lovely evenings out on the freshly watered lawn."

Related Characters: Ila Das (speaker), Nanda Kaul , Raka**Related Themes:** **Page Number:** 133**Explanation and Analysis**

Ila Das either does not notice or does not care that neither

Nanda Kaul nor Raka are interested in the stories she's telling at the tea table, so she prattles on and on. By this point, she's gotten up to describing the years during which Nanda Kaul was married to the Vice-Chancellor and Ila Das was a teacher at the college and a frequent visitor to the Vice-Chancellor's house. Nanda Kaul watches—and judges—silently. Notably, she finds Ila Das's romanticizing of the past offensive in this moment, although the book has strongly implicated her for the same crime in the stories she told earlier to Raka. This points toward Nanda Kaul's inability to be honest with herself about her feelings and motives. She holds others to a standard she doesn't apply to herself—or, at any rate, only applies after the fact, when it will no longer change her actions.

Importantly, the book has made it very clear that Ila Das has turned her attention to Raka by the time Nanda Kaul sits back in her chair, silently judging her friend. This implies that part of what Nanda Kaul finds so offensive and horrifying is the specter of her own actions. She recognizes in Ila Das's desperation her own desire to make Raka like her, and this makes her uncomfortable. But rather than facing that discomfort, she tries to avoid it.

happy memories leaving her—and Nanda Kaul—alone to confront the truth of the world and their lives. In real time, the book records the bitterness of the shift. But it isn't until the two women arrive at this point that they're able to speak honestly to each other. And so, as painful as the truth is, the book continues to maintain that it's better to face it than to try to live in a fantasy world.

Importantly, this passage gives readers more insight into Nanda Kaul's character and motivations, too. It helps to illuminate why she feels so bitter about her past. Undoubtedly, it contained many of the pleasant things that Ila Das recalls, but the emptiness at the heart of her marriage rendered those things—and the duties she performed as mistress of that world—empty and meaningless to her. But as much as Nanda Kaul continues to insist to herself that she has retired from or lost the habit of caring for others, her actions suggest otherwise. In this case, readers learn that she's been paying attention to what happens to Ila Das, implying that she still cares about her friend's fate. This, in turn, contradicts her ongoing insistence that she is perfectly happy alone and that she neither cares for nor wants anyone involved in her life.

Part 3, Chapter 6 Quotes

☝☝ Now the pink lichees, the badminton games and piano tunes fled from Ila Das's side, leaving behind a shriveled, shaking thing. Little by little, all those sweetnesses, those softnesses died or departed, leaving her every minute drier, dustier and more desperate.

Nanda Kaul knew: she had followed this despairing progress from not too great a distance. So Ila Das could turn to her with a harsh honesty that was as real as her memory-making had been, and Nanda Kaul knew how real each was in its turn, how they came together, one bitter, corroded edge joining the other, making up this wretched whole.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul, Ila Das, Vice-Chancellor, Miss David

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 134

Explanation and Analysis

Tea ends abruptly when Ila Das gets too caught up in her own story and accidentally invokes the name of Miss David, the woman with whom the Vice-Chancellor carried on a life-long affair even while he was married to Nanda Kaul. This harsh and bitter truth bursts the rosy bubble of Ila Das's

Part 3, Chapter 7 Quotes

☝☝ "Isn't it absurd," she rattled on, "how helpless our upbringing made us, Nanda. We thought we were being equipped with the very best—French lessons, piano lessons, English governesses—my, all that only to find it left us helpless, positively handicapped!" She cracked with laughter like an old egg, "Now if I were only of the peasants in my village, perhaps I'd manage quite well. Grow a pumpkin vine, keep a goat, pick up kindling in the forest for fire—and perhaps I could cut down those thirty rupees I need to twenty-five, to twenty—but not, I think, less." Almost crying, she turned to Nanda Kaul. "Do you think I could do with less?"

Related Characters: Ila Das (speaker), Nanda Kaul

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 139

Explanation and Analysis

As she prepares to leave Carignano and the brief interlude of quiet and peace in her impoverished and difficult life, Ila Das laments the privileged upbringing that left her so ill prepared to handle what life has brought her. She had the best of all advantages in early childhood, but the only life English governesses, French tutors, and piano lessons prepared her for is the kind of life Nanda Kaul had: the

pampered wife of another wealthy and powerful man. Nanda Kaul's own experience suggests the hollowness of this ideal, too, because even with the stability and privilege she continues to enjoy up to this day, she isn't much happier overall than Ila Das is.

In this passage, Ila Das directly criticizes her society on two accounts. First of all, times have changed: the French and English teachers belong to the colonial past when outside powers held sway in India. Second, and more importantly, the traditional roles for females aren't just limiting and don't just lead to unhappiness (which was Nanda Kaul's experience)—they are dangerous. They create a class of women who lack the skills necessary to survive in the world as it is.

suggests that the way she was brought up is a disadvantage both because it belongs to the colonial India of the British Raj rather than the modern India in which she lives and because the limited expectations and prospects for women (marriage) meant she wasn't taught to do anything useful with or for herself.

This passage also investigates the subtle ways in which privilege shifts a person's worldview. Ila Das is all too aware intellectually that she has fallen a long way from the world of her childhood. Yet, her flash of distaste for the grainseller shows how difficult it is to relieve herself of her upper-class biases. This in turn suggests that she may be alienating the villagers—whose poverty she clearly doesn't respect—even more than she realizes. Likewise, her fear of falling into debt (rather than the much more imminent danger of starvation) reflects her inability to reorient her perspective to match her circumstances.

Part 3, Chapter 11 Quotes

☛ Once under the chestnut trees of the Lower Mall, Ila Das tried to tease herself out of her panic. Why was she afraid? Of whom? She was not in debt to anyone in the bazaar. No, Ila Das would never take a loan, never. Ooh, what would her father have thought if she had? She gave a little spurring giggle at the thought of her father, in his fawn waistcoat with the gold watch chain cascading out of his pocket, knowing his daughter, groomed by a long line of governesses and ayahs, to be in debt to some hairy, half-dressed shopkeeper.

But here she stopped herself. Why did she think of that kindly concerned man in the grainshop as hairy, half-dressed? Now when would she ever get over that pompous education of her, leave it all behind and learn to deal with the world, now her world, as it was?

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Ila Das, Grainseller

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 151-152

Explanation and Analysis

As Ila Das descends the mountain toward her hovel in one of the valley's impoverished villages, she stops at the bazaar to buy some grain for dinner. She can't afford it, although she appreciates the fact that the grainseller is kind and concerned about her wellbeing. He warns her to be careful going home in the dark. She's too proud to admit concern to his face, although she does feel fear as she continues down the road. In this passage, she further reflects on the way her privileged upbringing left her unprepared to handle the life she now lives—a theme she introduced when she was talking to Nanda Kaul earlier. Yet again, this passage

Part 3, Chapter 12 Quotes

☛ The last of the light had left the valley. It was already a deep violet and only the Kasauli ridge, where Carignano stood invisibly, was still bright with sunlight, russet and auburn, copper and brass. An eagle took off from the peak of Monkey Point, lit up like a torch in the sky, and dropped slowly down into the valley, lower and lower, till it was no more than a sere leaf, a scrap of burnt paper, drifting on currents of air, silently.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Ila Das

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 153

Explanation and Analysis

Ila Das pauses momentarily and looks back on the way she came up the mountain. This passage describes what she sees. It uses the topography of Kasauli as well as vibrant imagery to comment further on the theme of privilege and responsibility that Ila Das's visit to Carignano raised. At this moment, it's still bright and beautiful on the ridge where Nanda Kaul lives. But Ila Das's life is dark, terrifying, and dangerous. The physical distance between the two women—as well as their positions relative to each other—graphically underscores how different the trajectories of their lives have been, even though they started out with nearly identical lives. Although both were limited by traditional expectations and gender roles for

females that are reflected in their education, Nanda Kaul still enjoys wealth and privilege. She can live alone and pay a servant to attend to her needs. Ila Das has fallen so low that she can't go any farther.

The flight of the eagle traces the path of Ila Das's life, which started in a bright, happy place but has drifted and fallen lower and lower. The initially grand eagle looks, by the time it falls into the valley's shadows, little more than a dried-up leaf or piece of ash floating on the breeze. These images map on to Ila Das, whom the book has previously described as dried up and insubstantial, too. And the fact that the eagle drops out of view entirely before Ila Das turns her attention back to the road stands as an ominous sign suggesting that oblivion is coming for her too, and soon.

Part 3, Chapter 13 Quotes

☛ No, no, it is a lie! No, it cannot be. It was a lie—Ila was not raped, not dead. It was all a lie, all. She had lied to Raka, lied about everything. Her father had never been to Tibet [...] They had not had bears and leopards in their home, nothing but overfed dogs and bad-tempered parrots. Nor had her husband loved and cherished her and kept her like a queen [...] And her children—[...] she] neither understood nor loved them. She did not live here alone by choice—she lived here alone because that was what she was forced to do, reduced to doing. All those graces and glories with which she had tried to captivate Raka were only a fabrication: they helped her to sleep at night, they were tranquillizers, pills. She had lied to Raka. And Ila had lied, too. Ila, too, had lied, had tried.

Related Characters: Nanda Kaul , Raka, Ila Das

Related Themes:



Page Number: 158

Explanation and Analysis

When a police officer from a village in the valley calls and tells Nanda Kaul what has happened to Ila Das, she cannot believe it. She drops the phone receiver and flails about mentally as she tries to take in the news. This passage features free indirect discourse—sharing Nanda Kaul's thoughts and emotions with readers not as a direct quote but filtered through the voice of the narrator. This technique places readers directly into Nanda Kaul's point of view, even though the book is written in the third person.

Nanda Kaul lists the lies she has told to others, but she also begins to acknowledge the lies she's told herself. And the biggest of these is that she wants to live alone, to be alone, when in fact she's desperate for companionship and love. It's just that the people in her life—until she met Raka, at least—neither understood her nor were understandable to her. She realizes that she needs others, but it's too late. Raka has long since rejected her, and now Ila Das, her only other friend, is dead. Belatedly, Nanda Kaul begins to see the costs of lying to others and herself, a realization rendered more painful because of the guilt she bears on account of the way her deception caused harm to others, especially Ila. By avoiding her responsibilities, she hurt others—her children, her friend—in the same way she hurt herself: by showing a lack of love and companionship. Tragically, she can do nothing to atone for her choices, so her story stands as a stark example, warning readers not to make similar mistakes.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PART 1, CHAPTER 1

From the garden of her hilltop house, named Carignano, Nanda Kaul sees a mailman struggling slowly up the mountain road. She fervently hopes that he's not coming for her: she loves the house on account of its quiet solitude, and letters carry nothing but demands. She stares at the mailman, but he doesn't receive her psychic message to stay away.

The book opens with an image of Nanda Kaul alone, self-sufficient and content in her environment. Nanda Kaul sees herself this solitary way. But her irritation at the mailman's approach suggests that she struggles to maintain this solitude because she can't control the outside world. It's interesting that the only thing Nanda Kaul can imagine him bringing is a demand, although readers will have to learn more about her to understand why.



While the mailman toils up the road, Nanda Kaul surveys her surroundings. She loves the barren, light-drenched landscape of Kasauli. From Carignano, she can see the Himalayas to the north and the Indian plains to the south. Apricot trees stand in the lee of the house. Nanda Kaul picks up a fallen apricot and inspects it. It's bruised, and when she discards it, a **hoopoe** swoops down and snatches it up. The hoopoe and its shrilly screaming fledglings nest under the eaves near Nanda Kaul's bedroom. She doesn't enjoy this. She does love the house, however, and she can't imagine what it was like before it was hers.

In this moment, the hoopoe feeding its young becomes an emblem of familial and domestic responsibilities. Nanda Kaul rejects these responsibilities as she rejects the imperfect, bruised apricot. But she still experiences the disruption of the birds' presence. Nanda Kaul can no more ignore them than whoever sends her letters, even if she wants to.



PART 1, CHAPTER 2

A British colonel named MacDougall built the house in 1843 in hopes that the mountain air would prove wholesome for his sickly wife and children. It didn't. After their deaths, the house stood empty, but not quiet: one day its roof blew off in a thunderstorm and decapitated a poor laborer nearly two miles away in another town. After the roof was replaced, the pastor of Kasuli's only church lived in the house with his wife. He planted—and loved—the apricot trees. His wife hated him so much she tried daily to murder him until her own accidental death. He later died in a tuberculosis sanatorium, and his ghost allegedly still haunts Carignano.

Carignano has a vexed relationship with domesticity. The history described in this passage suggests circumscribed roles for women. The book doesn't reveal the sources of the pastor's wife's hatred, but it's clear that she was unhappy in the context of her marriage and wanted to escape it by any means necessary. And while MacDougall built the house out of evident affection for his wife and children, affection couldn't save them from suffering.



Afterward, a series of English maiden ladies occupied the house, starting with Miss Appleby, a former governess with a wicked temper, who once severely beat the gardener for planting marigold flowers. Then it was occupied by Miss Lawrence; the two Miss Hughes, who planted the yellow creeper rose which blooms extravagantly all around the house and garden for one month each year; and Miss Jane Shrewsbury, who brewed herbal medicine and once tried to save her cook from choking by stabbing him in the neck to create a passage for breathing. He died anyway, and her actions caused a brief scandal. Miss Weaver and Miss Polson lived in the house before and during World War II, entertaining British soldiers far from the front lines. But they fled, along with the rest of the British, on the eve of Indian independence in 1947.

The single women who occupied the house model the kind of carefree, autonomous existence that Nanda Kaul wants. But they are members of a special class of women—maiden or unmarried ladies—without familial responsibilities. As white British women living in colonized India, they're also privileged. It isn't until the political situation changes, the book suggests, that Indian women like Nanda Kaul can fully experience the societal positions formerly reserved for their colonial overlords.



PART 1, CHAPTER 3

The mailman pauses under the shade of a chestnut tree to wait for Ram Lal, Nanda Kaul's cook, on his way back from the market. He wants to finish the ascent with Ram Lal's company. Although it would be easier, his sense of discipline prevents him from just asking the cook to take the letter up from the gate. Ram Lal grunts a wordless greeting at the mailman before they struggle up the path to Carignano. At the top of the hill, the mailman shuffles through his bag, then hands Nanda Kaul one envelope. She carries it—at arm's length like it's dangerous—to the verandah.

Carignano's isolation and the difficulty of the climb actively frustrate visitors. It's clear that Nanda Kaul has gone out of her way to erect barriers between herself and the people who dare to send her letters. But it's also clear that she can only survive in this remote place because she can afford to pay a servant to attend to her errands and needs. This suggests that she needs others more than she can—or will—admit.



PART 1, CHAPTER 4

Nanda Kaul sits in the cane chair on her verandah and looks at the riot of flowers and fruits in the garden: the apricots ripening on the trees, the potted geraniums and fuchsias. **Birds** swoop through the garden and she can hear the steady drone of cicadas. Nanda's eyes rise past the garden to the rooftops of the city below. Then, finally, she turns her attention to the letter, written by her "most exasperating" daughter Asha.

Nanda Kaul so dreads whatever demand the letter carries that she can't even notice the beauty and peacefulness of her garden. It's notable that she can only imagine relationships taking something from her. And with that threat constantly hanging over her head, her isolation isn't very freeing or peaceful.



Nanda Kaul already knows some of the drama surrounding her granddaughter Tara, who is married to a cheating and abusive diplomat. They're supposed to be going to Geneva, but their daughter Raka has recently had typhoid fever and is still too ill to travel. Nanda Kaul feels an almost physical resistance to opening the letter. It explains in detail how Asha managed to reconcile Tara and her husband, and all the work Asha had to do to prepare Tara to travel to Europe. And it announces that Asha and Tara have decided to send Raka to recuperate with Nanda Kaul over the summer before traveling on to Geneva. Nanda Kaul drops the letter back into her lap and looks toward the horizon as she wrestles with feelings of "anger [...] disappointment [...] loathing" and helplessness to oppose her daughter's plan.

Although Nanda Kaul has yet to reveal any of her own history to readers, it clearly has to do with domestic life. She resents her children and grandchildren as much as she resents the loud baby hoopoes nesting in the eaves of her house. And she finds something particularly difficult in facing the sad story of Tara's marriage. In turn, Tara's story—especially given her mother's evident collusion with her abusive husband—suggests the limitations and violence imposed on women in early 20th-century Indian society.



PART 1, CHAPTER 5

Nanda Kaul walks to the back of the house. The ground falls away into a deep **ravine**. This gorge, cluttered and choked with rocks and debris, reminds her of the overwhelming responsibilities of her earlier life. She was married to the Vice-Chancellor of a small university, and she spent her days amid a swirl of activity: tending to the needs of their many children, entertaining her husband's guests and their wives, overseeing the work of the servants. She fears that Raka's arrival will replace the responsibility she was so anxious to escape. It seems unfair that after so many years of sacrifice, she isn't even allowed to enjoy her hard-earned solitude. She wishes to be free, like the **eagles** soaring high above the hills. But she fears that she is stuck in a domestic role, like the cuckoo she can hear in the garden.

Nanda Kaul's home sits at a remove from the fray of her messy family life, but it's not as big a remove as she wants it to be. The messy and dangerous ravine sits just on the other side of a fence, just as Carignano is only a letter or a taxi-ride away from Asha or Raka. Looking at the ravine, she reflects on what she ran from in her old life. The image of her married life confirms the repeated suggestions in earlier chapters that Nanda Kaul resents domesticity. But it's also clear that she wasn't able to make as clean a break as she would like to believe; she fears that she'll be trapped yet again in a domestic role, yet she accepts Asha's plan without dissent.



PART 1, CHAPTER 6

Nanda Kaul returns to her cane chair on the verandah. The insistent, shrill cry of the telephone interrupts her peace. Against her better judgement, she answers it. On the other end of the line, she hears the "shrill and strident" voice of her childhood friend Ila Das. The sound is so "hideous" that it takes a few minutes for Nanda Kaul to understand what Ila Das is saying. She wants to come for a visit. Nanda Kaul tries to use Raka as an excuse but the prospect of meeting a great-granddaughter just excites Ila Das more. Reluctantly, Nanda Kaul promises to summon Ila Das after she gets Raka settled.

Nanda Kaul finds everything about the interaction—from the mere sound of Ila Das's strident voice to what she actually says—annoying. It's worth considering why this is the case, since Ila Das is allegedly her friend. In this moment, Ila Das shows more excitement and happiness about seeing a loved one than Nanda Kaul does, and this functions as a rebuke of Nanda Kaul's coldness.



PART 1, CHAPTER 7

In the oppressive heat of midafternoon, Nanda Kaul lies motionless on her bed, trying to imagine herself as a tree trunk, or a stone pillar—as an inanimate object unruffled by the heat and unbothered by the incessant buzzing of flies and cicadas or the brief quarrel of **parrots** in the trees. Nanda Kaul has been practicing this stillness for decades; she started when she was still the Vice-Chancellor's wife, and their small children and their guests overran her house. Every day, for one hour, she would retreat to her bedroom and try to lie in silent stillness, even though the sounds of the children and the servants constantly distracted her. As the hour progressed, it became harder to ignore everything, to choose not to respond. The effort would take her breath away.

Two related things become clear as Nanda Kaul tries to nap during the heat of the day. First, the heat and the noise of the parrots in the trees remind her of how little she controls in her life. She has no more power over the parrots than over her family. In response, she tries to practice self-control. But the degree of effort this exercise requires—both in the past and in the present—suggests that it does not come to her as naturally as she wishes others (or herself) to believe. Still, it's clear from the anguished tone of her memory how much she resented the caregiving duties she was expected to perform during her marriage.



Nanda Kaul remembers how immediately her responsibilities would flood back in on her when she rose from her bed. She wonders if she was ever alone in that period of her life. She wracks her brain and remembers one evening after a badminton and garden party. She had gotten up from her bed and paced the lawn in the moonlight while the house slept. From the shadows of the trees, she watched her husband, the Vice-Chancellor, return from bringing one very special guest home. She watched him go inside and waited until the light clicked off in the bedroom where he sleeps apart from her. She remembers feeling completely alone in that one moment. In the present, Nanda Kaul feels the first cool breeze of the afternoon, and she rises from bed.

This memory gives insight into Nanda Kaul's character. Clearly, relationships have caused her pain in the past, in the form of her children's incessant demands and in the emotional emptiness at the heart of her marriage to the Vice-Chancellor. Nanda Kaul has time to herself because her husband is having an affair with one of the party guests, and she clearly knows about it—that's why they sleep in separate bedrooms. Thus, while she tries to cast this as a moment of personal triumph, the book clearly suggests that it was also a moment of pain.



PART 1, CHAPTER 8

As Nanda Kaul takes her tea on the verandah in the cool shade of late afternoon, she reads *The Pillow Book of Sei Shonagon*. It includes a picturesque description of the kind of dilapidated house in which a single woman should live. Nanda Kaul loves that passage. Holding the book in her hand, Nanda Kaul rises from her chair and walks out into the garden. As she has so many times before, she admires the view out over the plains. She has often wished that she could travel in time to get a 19th-century English watercolorist to capture the vista—with its light and space—in a painting.

Sei Shonagon was a medieval noblewoman who lived in the household of the Japanese empress. Her book lists observations and musings much like a diary, although her literary skill turned it into a valuable historical record and piece of literature. This choice of afternoon reading suggests Nanda Kaul's intelligence and taste, hinting that she was her educated husband's intellectual equal, despite his lack of affection for her. The passage at hand emphasizes Nanda Kaul's wish for the freedom and isolation of her solitude.



Dusk gathers, and lights begin to come on in the surrounding communities. Nanda Kaul retreats to the drawing room, where she reads more sections of [The Pillow Book](#) before returning to "When a Woman Lives Alone." Although Carignano isn't nearly as rundown as Sei Shonagon describes, Nanda Kaul thinks that the simple austerity of her home would have pleased the medieval Japanese lady. Carignano is so different from the house she lived in with the Vice-Chancellor, with its bevy of servants, endless stream of guests, and mob of children. Life there was excessive and disordered, and she was so glad to leave it all behind. She worries that Raka's arrival might reintroduce chaos into her carefully measured life.

There's a clear difference between what Sei Shonagon describes in her passage as romantic and charming and the way Nanda Kaul lives, yet Nanda Kaul grants herself the Japanese noblewoman's approval. This suggests that Nanda Kaul may not be fully honest with herself, and readers should be wary of accepting her assessments blindly. This also hints subtly that Nanda Kaul makes her life fit a preordained image (the exact opposite of the marriage in which she felt trapped) rather than because she truly likes it this way.



PART 1, CHAPTER 9

Once, Nanda Kaul took care of others with an almost religious fervor. But the source of that devotion dried up after the Vice-Chancellor died, when her children helped her pack up the house and delivered her to Carignano. She remembers how she "drifted" around the garden on that first day. She found it perfect in its austerity. She can't imagine adding a child—Raka—to this setting any more than she would have added a fountain to the dry garden.

The book never makes it fully clear how much of Nanda Kaul's service to others arose in response to the expectations of her society and her husband and how much represents her own desire to connect with others. This, in turn, suggests the ways that sexist and patriarchal limitations can poison a person's natural inclination through coercion.



On the day before Raka's arrival, Nanda Kaul visits Ram Lal in the kitchen. She helplessly asks what he will cook for the girl—she left her cookbooks behind when she left her old life. Tentatively, Ram Lal suggests potato chips with ketchup. This sounds cheerful, if inadequate, to Nanda Kaul. She leaves the kitchen, and Ram Lal frets over his advancing years.

Nanda Kaul once knew what to do in situations like this. She could still pull up that knowledge if she wanted to. But she doesn't—she prefers to abdicate adult responsibilities for others, like her servant Ram Lal, to take care of. While her past life makes this attitude understandable, it still suggests a concerning selfishness and lack of consideration for how she impacts others—especially those with less privilege.



PART 1, CHAPTER 10

On the day of Raka's arrival, Nanda Kaul sends Ram Lal to fetch her great-granddaughter. While fussing over Raka's bedroom, she runs into the bedpost, bruising herself. As she stares at the bruise, she tries to remember Raka. But her children—and even more so her grandchildren and great-grandchildren—all run together in her mind. Nothing differentiates Raka from the rest. It seems only disaster—Tara's unhappy marriage, Tara's sister Vina's frequent illnesses and injuries—stand out in Nanda Kaul's mind. Soon, though, Raka will be an actual child who needs care. Nanda Kaul worries about her ability to do so.

Nanda Kaul injures herself just before Raka's arrival, and her physical bruise matches the sense of grievance she feels toward the daughter and granddaughter who sent the little girl to her. This moment also insinuates that Raka's visit will mark Nanda Kaul's life in a noticeable way, and it darkly hints that it will be painful rather than pleasant. Only disasters, after all, seem to make an impression on Nanda Kaul.



PART 2, CHAPTER 1

Raka's name means "moon," but as she enters Nanda Kaul's garden, she looks more like a bug, perhaps a leggy mosquito, than a peaceful moon. To Raka, Nanda Kaul looks like just another part of the landscape, like a grey rock or a silvery pine tree. She hears the incessant sound of the cicadas and catches sight of the **hoopoes** darting among the branches of the apricot trees. She and Nanda Kaul embrace coldly.

Neither Raka nor Nanda Kaul has very favorable feelings toward the other at first. They remain wholly separate from each other. Nanda Kaul sees Raka as a pesky annoyance, and Raka barely sees Nanda Kaul at all. The following chapters will track the development and consequences of these attitudes.



PART 2, CHAPTER 2

During the heat of the afternoon, the brightness of the sun draws Raka to the window of her room. It looks down the mountainside to the distant plains. After a while, she slips through the window and begins to explore the garden. The cluttered, rocky **ravine** fascinates her. A little way down its length she can see a large, ominous-looking factory that draws her curiosity. Skirting along the garden fence, she circles around to the outbuilding where Ram Lal is napping. Because he can't answer her questions about the factory, she climbs to the highest part of the garden to look out over the countryside and wait.

Nanda Kaul mainly worries about Raka's visit because she doesn't want to have to go back to taking care of others. But Raka doesn't seem to need much care in this moment. And it's already clear that she doesn't feel drawn to the great-grandmother that just seems (to her) to be part of the scenery. Instinctively, she turns from someone who doesn't want her and toward the kindly Ram Lal. Notably, she's immediately drawn not to the garden's flowers or shady apricot trees, but the wilderness of the ravine.



PART 2, CHAPTER 3

When Raka finally hears Ram Lal making tea, she slips into the kitchen to ask about the factory. It is the Pasteur Institute, he says, and it makes the serum used to prevent rabies infections in those bitten by wild dogs. Ram Lal himself had to have the shots—14 in all—once. He warns her to stay away from the gorge because the factory's refuse attracts **jackals** and often infects them with rabies, too.

Ram Lal serves Raka and Nanda Kaul tea on the verandah. Raka refuses to meet her great-grandmother's eyes. Nanda Kaul wonders what the girl will do to entertain herself. She is determined to leave Raka to her own devices, refusing to be drawn into her great-granddaughter's world. She asks what Raka plans to do, but Raka does not reply.

Raka goes out of her way to avoid Nanda Kaul and to talk to Ram Lal instead. The Pasteur Institute's role in the community reflects a country at a turning point in the second half of the 20th century: diseases like rabies are still endemic but there are modern treatments available for those interested in taking them.



To Nanda Kaul, Raka is an enigma. The little girl refuses not only to answer questions but also to look into her great-grandmother's eyes or do anything else that might give Nanda Kaul a glimpse of who she is or what makes her tick. She is as self-sufficient as Nanda Kaul wishes to be—but isn't. Despite her so-called refusal to be drawn into Raka's world, Nanda Kaul cannot suppress her curiosity.



PART 2, CHAPTER 4

Nanda Kaul writes a letter to Asha reporting Raka's safe arrival. In it, she admits none of her resentment or curiosity about the girl, who refuses to say where she goes or what she does during the day. She simply disappears or reappears—covered in dust and scratches—as the mood strikes her. Intensely curious, Nanda Kaul feels just as annoyed by Raka's absence as her presence. She resents the girl's instinctive reclusion, especially since it comes to her naturally while Nanda Kaul had to practice and sacrifice her own way to solitude.

Not only does Nanda Kaul refuse to share her thoughts with others, but barely seems willing to admit them to herself. But Nanda Kaul does have intense feelings toward Raka—negative ones—that come not just from her resentment at being forced back into a maternal, caregiving role, but at her growing realization that Raka has the kind of freedom Nanda Kaul thought she herself had.



PART 2, CHAPTER 5

Each day, Raka explores the **ravine**, fascinated by the trash that clogs it. One day, she finds a giant yellow **snake** sunning on a rock. She stands and looks at it for a long time before moving on. The Pasteur Institute's sky-piercing chimneys emit a medicinal smell from the boiling serum. Dust chokes the plains below. One day, Raka scrambles up the hill in the wrong place, accidentally coming up in the garden of the Kasauli Club. She's dismayed, but in the heat of the day no one is outside to notice her slipping under Carignano's fence.

Earlier, Nanda Kaul read Sei Shonagon's description of the isolated woman's dilapidated house and thought with pleasure about how controlled and orderly Carignano is. The messiness and trash of the ravine, however, suggest that real freedom—the kind Raka has and the kind Nanda Kaul aspires to—is more like Shonagon's vision. It's messy and a little dangerous. Nanda Kaul's ideal is more like the country-club version of reality Raka runs away from in dismay.



PART 2, CHAPTER 6

When Raka gets back to Carignano, she talks to Ram Lal as he heats water for her afternoon bath. She tells him about the **snake**—it's a rat snake, he tells her—and the interesting things she sees in the **ravine**. She confesses that she wants to see a jackal, despite Ram Lal's warnings. Ram Lal thinks that Nanda Kaul should take Raka to the Kasauli Club to play with other children. Raka knows she wouldn't like it—she never has fit into the world of other children.

Before the water is hot, a dust storm races up the mountain. Ram Lal and Raka shelter in the kitchen. Ram Lal frets about wildfires, which are not uncommon in the area. Raka describes the shell of a **burned cottage** she saw on the mountain, and Ram Lal tells her about the English lady who lived there and who went crazy when it burned. She lost her hair and eyebrows to the fire while trying to rescue her cat. The dust storm passes without spreading any flames, and Ram Lal carries the kettle of warm water to the bathroom. Nanda Kaul watches from a window.

PART 2, CHAPTER 7

After tea one afternoon, Nanda Kaul places her cup down assertively and announces her plan to accompany Raka on her afternoon walk. This upsets Raka, who cherishes the isolation. But she cannot say no. As they walk awkwardly along the path to Monkey Point, unaccustomed to each other's company, Nanda Kaul points out various sites of interest, from the **burned cottage** (whose story Ram Lal already told Raka) to the army installations on the hilltops, complaining about the number of tourists and soldiers overrunning the town.

The sound of **monkeys** squabbling in the treetops interrupts Nanda Kaul's tour-guide patter, and for a moment she and Raka are united in their laughing appreciation of the silly animals' antics. They admire a mother monkey calmly cradling her wrinkled baby. The monkeys leap onto the roof of a dilapidated house, and children and servants flood out to chase them away. Nanda Kaul and Raka resume their walk, and—much to Raka's dismay—Nanda Kaul resumes her tour. Unexpectedly, she suggests that Raka could stay and attend school nearby in Sanawar. Raka shakes her head in refusal, then runs on ahead, horrified by the very thought of “discipline, order and obedience.” Nanda Kaul is hurt by Raka's rejection.

Even as he and Raka strike up an odd friendship, Ram Lal finds the little girl disquieting. The kind of life he describes, one of country-club playdates with other privileged children, isn't right for her, and Raka knows it. What's more, she's content with her life even though it looks strange or inappropriate to others. She knows herself well—another arena in which she surpasses her great-grandmother.



As time goes on, readers get more and more insight into the fragility of Nanda Kaul's carefully constructed existence. Her relatives and friends ignore her desire to be alone, and even when she's left to herself, she runs the risk of wildfires. And, as she watches Ram Lal talk to Raka through the window, Nanda Kaul betrays a growing interest in her great-granddaughter that belies her sense of isolation.



Nanda Kaul shows herself to be a tourist in the wilderness that Raka effortlessly claims as her own territory. Clearly, Nanda Kaul and Raka see the world through very different eyes. Nanda Kaul cannot help but focus on other people—even if she resents their encroachment—while Raka seems to notice everything except people. Raka has what Nanda Kaul says she wants, but it's growing clear that Nanda Kaul cannot separate herself from the world as completely as Raka.



The animals in this book represent absolute freedom—and freedom sometimes entails chaos. This moment could bring Raka and Nanda Kaul together—if Nanda Kaul understood or truly empathized with Raka. She can't. She falls back into the caregiving role she claims to hate but cannot free herself from, and this in turn alienates Raka. Nanda Kaul's instinctive conventionality rears its head in her suggestion that Raka attend a nearby school. Readers should note how quickly Nanda Kaul has moved from not caring what the child does with her days to insinuating herself into Raka's explorations. What she says she wants and what she does are not the same.



PART 2, CHAPTER 8

At the foot of Monkey Point, Nanda Kaul sits on one of the benches the city has installed for tourists, telling Raka to go on without her. She doesn't have the energy to make the final ascent. Relieved, Raka scrabbles up the hill to the summit where she stands buffeted by the wind. Nanda Kaul is both alarmed and impressed by Raka's headlong climb.

Atop Monkey Point, Raka breathes freely for the first time since the walk began. She relishes secrecy and isolation, and she hates that Nanda Kaul imposed herself on the trip and now sits watching her from the benches below. But her resentment seems to blow away in the wind, and the sight of **eagles** circling on the warm currents of air over the plains far below rallies her. With delight, she imagines herself as a shipwrecked sailor alone on a deserted island. She only remembers her great-grandmother and descends after darkness falls.

This moment illustrates the huge gulf between Raka and Nanda Kaul. Although they share an affinity for solitude and the harsh, mountainous terrain of Kasauli, this scene makes it clear that Nanda Kaul will never be more than a tourist in the wilderness, unlike the wild and free Raka.



Solitude suits Raka in a way that Nanda Kaul cannot understand. Raka is so radically independent that she seems to forget Nanda Kaul the moment she climbs up the mountain. And, unlike her great-grandmother, her resentments blow away easily in the wind. She is, in this moment and elsewhere in the book, as free as the eagles she admires in the valley below.



PART 2, CHAPTER 9

After Raka's clear rejection and resentment on their one walk, Nanda Kaul doesn't try to accompany Raka again. But when Raka slips from the garden in the afternoons, Nanda Kaul puts down her book and watches to see where she goes. Raka rarely sticks to the paved expanse of the Upper or Lower Mall—in Nanda Kaul's sight—for long. She slips beneath the railing to explore the **ravine** or forays to nearby villages to watch the harvest being brought in. She rarely encounters other people.

Nanda Kaul, who prizes isolation and privacy above all else, nevertheless cannot stop trying to draw Raka out of her shell. She wants to understand what drives the girl. One day, Nanda Kaul suggests that Raka visit the club to play with the other children. Raka—thinking in horror about the few times her parents tried to encourage her to socialize—points out that Nanda Kaul doesn't go there either. This delights Nanda Kaul, who leans over and conspiratorially says that Raka is “*exactly like*” her. Raka instinctively draws back from this overt display of emotion. Nanda Kaul is, in turn, surprised by her own outburst and hurt by Raka's reaction.

From Nanda Kaul's initial reaction to Raka's arrival, it seems logical to expect that she would perceive Raka's rejection of her attention as a blessing rather than a curse. Instead, her drive to figure Raka out suggests that she was always more interested in her than she wanted to admit. And it hints at her growing awareness of how far she falls short of her ideal of freedom.



Nanda Kaul never fully explains her interest in Raka—the book thus suggests that she may not have insight into her own actions in this regard. But readers can observe a few clues here. First, Nanda Kaul knows that Raka effortlessly possesses the freedom and autonomy she herself wants. Understanding Raka in this regard could help Nanda Kaul get what she wants—or thinks she wants. Second, Nanda Kaul seems irked that Raka doesn't need her. Her caretaking instincts do not seem to have been extinguished as she suggested earlier.



Nanda Kaul and Raka sit in tense silence for several moments as Raka watches the **hoopoe** nest in the eaves of the house. Every day since her arrival, she had watched the adult hoopoes collecting food for their babies and fighting with the bulbuls (smaller birds) over the apricots. She knows the adult birds are waiting for the humans to vacate the verandah so they can fly to their babies. Eventually, she can't hold her tongue and she cries out that if they don't leave the birds won't be able to feed their babies. Nanda Kaul coolly dismisses Raka for her evening walk.

Raka may hold herself aloof from other people, but that doesn't mean that she is incapable of observing—or caring about—what happens around her. Nanda Kaul's inability to notice the hoopoe's distress mirrors her inability to notice—or care about—Raka's distress over Nanda Kaul's attempts to insinuate herself into the girl's world. Tellingly, Nanda Kaul resents the noise of the hoopoe babies because they represent domestic responsibilities to her. But Raka simply sees them as living creatures that deserve to go about their lives in peace—the attitude she wishes her grandmother would take toward her.



PART 2, CHAPTER 10

Eventually, Raka does go to the club—not during the afternoon, when the other children are there, but on the night of the summer party. Ram Lal told her about how lovely it was in the old days. So, on the night of the party, when she hears the band strike up, she puts a sweater over her pajamas, climbs out the window and slides down the hill to investigate. She comes first to the billiard room, where gangly teenaged boys play. She slips silently past the windows, then darts across the lawn, unnoticed by the adults in their party finery. Then she creeps along the verandah to one of the ballroom's open windows. She parts its green curtain to look inside.

Notably, Raka avoids the club under circumstances that might require her to engage with other people—especially other children—choosing to go as an observer to the summer ball. Her foray onto the club grounds recalls her forays into the ravine, with their attendant danger and revelation. It's notable that she can slip through such a busy scene. This aligns with her solitary behavior at Carignano, but it also suggests that she is unusually adept at making herself difficult to notice.



PART 2, CHAPTER 11

What Raka sees is not what Ram Lal described. The summer dance is a costume party, but not realizing that, Raka sees a horrifying series of nightmarish images: a man-sized cricket; another man with a skull and crossbones emblazoned across his chest; a somersaulting monkey; a mouse-woman; a convict with an untightened noose round his neck; a frightening doctor; a clown. They leap, dance, sing loudly, and chase each other around the ballroom. Perhaps the worst is a headless character who walks toward the windows as if it's seen Raka. Panicked, Raka flees, her mind clouded with memories of her father coming home drunk from parties to heap abuse on her mother Tara. She can almost hear her mother crying—then she realizes she hears a **jackal** crying in the **ravine**. She veers uphill toward Carignano.

The masquerade dance represents the height of cultivated contrivance. The partygoers hide their identities as a game, and this horrifies Raka in part because she herself seems incapable of such dishonesty. She cannot play the games of social nicety with Nanda Kaul, and she cannot understand the dancers as humans in costumes, instead seeing them as monsters. And the memories this moment awakens point to the trauma she endured in the context of her parents' unhappy and abusive marriage. Now it starts to make sense that she is so good at keeping herself out of sight, and so afraid of human attention. Yet, she cannot abandon herself to the wilds of the ravine, either, for in the end, she is still a human being. So, she returns home.



PART 2, CHAPTER 12

After the party, Raka becomes even more secretive and silent. She goes exploring. Usually, Nanda Kaul watches her surreptitiously from the windows, at least until Raka slips from view. One evening Raka comes home late, chanting “I don’t care for *anything*!” to herself. Nanda Kaul veils her frustration and worry by fussing over the hydrangeas, drying out slowly in the summer heat. As they walk around the garden together, Raka points out a light glowing from behind a distant hill. Nanda Kaul identifies it as a wildfire. They are common at this time of year, and this one seems comfortably far away. But it’s the first that Raka has seen, and it fascinates her. She can’t sleep and she gets up from bed over and over to check on its progress through the drawing room windows.

The previous chapter made it clear that Raka does care about some things—and also portrayed her sense of helplessness and vulnerability clearly enough for readers to understand why she’s trying to convince herself otherwise. Nanda Kaul is older and, in theory at least, wiser. But she won’t admit to herself how curious—and jealous—she is regarding Raka, either. Yet this lack of honesty doesn’t serve either person. Ram Lal raised the specter of wildfires earlier, but this is the first one Raka has seen. She’s drawn to its wild power but also a little afraid of its destructiveness—freedom is attractive, but it comes with dangers and costs.



PART 2, CHAPTER 13

Nanda Kaul watches Raka seek out Ram Lal with growing jealousy. Every evening, they sit near the kettle together, chatting. Ram Lal offers Raka the reassurance that Nanda Kaul is unable or unwilling to give her. Nanda Kaul can’t hear Ram Lal warning Raka to avoid the **ravine** at night, telling her that it’s haunted by *churails*, demonic spirits that eat the bones of the dead animals disposed of by Pasteur Institute.

Nanda Kaul’s isolation is a reaction to the resentment she felt at being trapped by familial responsibilities in her marriage. But now it’s becoming clear to readers that she might want more connection than she thinks. Ram Lal’s stories about churails emphasize this, as they point out the dangers of being too wild and too isolated.



Suddenly, a band of **langur monkeys** tears into the garden, swarming the fruit trees, throttling the hydrangea flowers, and invading the kitchen. Raka runs around, waving her arms to scare them off, while Ram Lal bangs on the kettle. Little boys run into the garden to help drive the monkeys away, and soon just one slow-moving mother and her baby are left. Ram Lal picks up a rock to throw at them, but Raka leaps on his arm, preventing him from doing so. In the ensuing silence, Nanda Kaul orders Ram Lal to dismiss the boys from the garden, seething inside herself over the fact that Raka hadn’t even turned toward her Nani to share the excitement.

The langur monkeys bring the kind of chaotic disruption to Carignano that Nanda Kaul feared. Notably, however, Raka’s arrival has barely created a ripple, at least on the superficial level of Nanda Kaul’s daily habits and activities. In stopping Ram Lal from throwing the rock, Raka protects the mother monkey from harm in a way that she’s incapable of protecting her own mother. And by aligning herself with the monkeys rather than the humans, she once again declares her own freedom and wildness. She belongs more to the natural world than the human one.



PART 2, CHAPTER 14

A letter arrives explaining that Tara has had another mental breakdown and Raka's visit must be extended. Nanda Kaul doesn't tell any of this to Raka, secretly relishing the sense that her great-granddaughter is now more dependent on her care. Raka still acts like she needs no one, much less Nanda Kaul. She doesn't even need—or want—to be tucked into bed at night. Nanda Kaul force herself to stay in her room, reading *The Travels of Marco Polo*, rather than checking on Raka. And although she reminds herself that she came to Carignano to be free from the responsibility of caring for others, she still yearns to perform this duty. She starts to consider leaving Carignano to Raka because she's the only relative who seems to appreciate it.

Nanda Kaul's opinions have changed markedly since the beginning of the book. She no longer resents Raka's presence. In fact, now she's bothered by Raka's independence; she clearly feels some genuine sense of fulfillment in caring for others, even if she resented being expected to do so. Now, she cannot convince herself that the life she has—a life alone and removed from others—is truly the life she wants. She must confront her real feelings if she wishes to resolve her unhappiness.



PART 2, CHAPTER 15

On a windy afternoon, Raka sits on the top of the knoll watching ring-nosed **parakeets** cracking into pinecones. When she joins Nanda Kaul on the verandah for tea, Nanda Kaul remarks on how unusual it is for a storm to come in from the north at this time of year. The storm falls before they finish tea, sending Nanda Kaul and Raka inside to the drawing room, where Raka notices a small bronze statue of the Buddha. Nanda Kaul explains that her father, Raka's great-great-grandfather, brought it back from Tibet. One year he headed east over the mountains from Kashmir to the Tibetan wilds.

Nanda Kaul and Raka start this chapter alone and would likely remain separate were it not for the rainstorm that drives them indoors. Nanda Kaul does a better job capitalizing on this opportunity than she did on the walk to Monkey Point, trading her superficial tour guide patter for an interesting and romantic story about her father's adventures in the wilderness—a story designed to capture and hold the attention of a child and of Raka specifically.



Nanda Kaul explains that her father was absent for years, during which he traveled all over Tibet, sleeping in tiger-infested forests, learning how to ride and shoot a bow and arrow, and hunting for musk deer. He met magicians who could turn day into night or conjure storms out of nowhere. And he collected many treasures. Raka wonders if he wrote about his adventures, but Nanda Kaul says he didn't. He was an explorer and a collector, not a writer.

This is the first readers hear about Nanda Kaul's family, so there is no way to judge the veracity of stories about conjurers and treasures. But alert readers might remember that in the previous chapter, the book specifically mentioned her reading about the adventures of 13th-century explorer Marco Polo, who traveled from Italy all the way to Japan, opening previously undiscovered trade routes. It's possible that Nanda Kaul is exaggerating or making things up in her desperation to connect with Raka.



PART 2, CHAPTER 16

Of all the treasures her father brought home, Nanda Kaul says, she kept only the statue. While they wait out the rainstorm, she tells Raka about all the treasures her husband, the Vice-Chancellor, collected. Nanda Kaul is not a collector; after her husband died, she distributed the treasures among her children and came to Carignano to live simply. Raka's interest wanes as the storm passes, distressing Nanda Kaul. As they step outside into an afternoon made cool and clear by the rain, she suddenly remembers a visit Tara made to Carignano many years ago, and how the little girl called rainy days "lily days." Raka asks why, but Nanda Kaul briskly shoos her off to take her afternoon walk.

The simple and austere Buddha statue represents the life that Nanda Kaul wishes to live—remember that the Buddha renounced his princely status and great wealth and lived a life of simple poverty on his way to enlightenment. But Nanda Kaul still defines her life by describing what she doesn't want rather than articulating what she does. Her life was too full before, so she emptied it. She isn't consciously considering the idea that she has made it too empty, but her memory of Tara suggests that she still has a capacity and an unmet yearning for connection.



PART 2, CHAPTER 17

The next day, Raka sees for herself what Tara meant, because the rain has caused wild lilies to bloom on the usually arid hills. Ram Lal picks armfuls of them to decorate the house. Over breakfast, Raka asks Nanda Kaul about when her mother was a child. Nanda Kaul answers briefly. She doesn't want Raka to realize how little she knows about her grandchildren. The lilies are the only thing that sticks out about Tara's childhood.

It's Nanda Kaul, not Raka, who holds the expectation that a family matriarch will remember and care about her descendants, no matter how numerous. And while Nanda Kaul resents feeling this responsibility, unlike Raka, she's unable to abandon social conventions so easily. She remains self-conscious about her perceived failure of memory and concern.



Then, Raka asks Nanda Kaul about the letter, about whether it said anything about Tara. Nanda Kaul briefly explains that Tara is ill again. Mentally, she curses her inability to offer comfort to the little girl. But Raka doesn't seem disturbed, or even very surprised. She merely rises from the table for her morning walk.

Readers have more insight into Raka than Nanda Kaul does—because they know a little about the trauma the girl has suffered, they can interpret her actions through that lens. The freedom and isolation she has—that Nanda Kaul envies—come at tremendous costs.



PART 2, CHAPTER 18

Raka flies from the house and up the hillside, intent on visiting the **burned cottage**. There is little left but a pile of charred stones. A little farther up lies an abandoned building site; the fire that consumed the little cottage dissuaded the landowners from their own building project. No one comes here except Raka and the wild **cuckoos** who scavenge the sere places for food and who beckon Raka to join them in the wilderness. The harsh landscape on the hill draws Raka too, its devastation inspiring and intriguing her.

The book creates an affinity between Raka and the burned cottage; both are isolated because of the harm they have suffered. The freedom Nanda Kaul envies in Raka arises at least in part at the cost of suffering and destruction. Indeed, although Raka didn't seem to be disturbed by news of her mother's illness, her flight to the burned cottage suggests some emotional upheaval.



Carignano is the best place Raka has ever lived, but she still finds it too confining. She only feels comfortable in broken and ravaged spaces, like the **ravine** and the wind-swept hilltops. She feels no attachment to the civilized world. As she runs off, the cottage's caretaker catches a glimpse of her—of “the crazy one from Carignano”—out of the corner of his eye.

Because readers' insight into Raka is limited, it's impossible to be certain how much of her independence arises from the trauma she's suffered and how much of it is natural to her spirit. But here the book reveals that some kernel of Raka's character has always stood apart from the civilized world.



PART 2, CHAPTER 19

One afternoon at tea, Nanda Kaul resumes telling Raka stories about her childhood in lush Kashmir. She describes rowing in its lakes and streams with her siblings and their houseboat vacations. Raka bluntly asks why Nanda Kaul came to arid Kasauli rather than going back to Kashmir, and Nanda Kaul cryptically remarks that that would be like trying to be young again, and that isn't something she wants.

At least part of the reason Nanda Kaul couldn't go back to Kashmir is because it no longer exists, at least as it did during her childhood under the British Raj. Kashmir was one of the areas claimed by both India and Pakistan during the Partition of 1947, leading to violence. India's colonial past continues to color its present.



Lost in her memories, Nanda Kaul tells Raka about her parents' estate, with its groves of almond trees and orchards. She describes the exotic fruits her father cultivated. Desperate to keep Raka's attention, Nanda Kaul drones on, describing the **animals** her father kept: a Himalayan bear that grew too big for its cage but too tame to be released back into the wild, and hissing, feral leopards that lived in a cage on the landing outside her father's room. Raka doesn't like the image of the caged animals, so Nanda Kaul switches to telling her about the half-tamed peacocks and the wild lemurs that were allowed to roam the estate's garden. Raka listens with growing consternation. Her great-grandmother used to leave her alone. She doesn't understand or like this newfound talkativeness.

On a superficial level, Nanda Kaul's story about her father's zoo illustrates her family's privilege and wealth. But it also speaks to unsettling power dynamics. The father cages wild animals for his own pleasure. Later, Nanda Kaul will feel trapped in the gilded cage of her superficially successful but emotionally empty marriage to the Vice-Chancellor. She resents this control and flees her cage as soon as she can. Yet, she's desperate enough for companionship in this moment that she's willing to use the lure of her story to trap Raka, too. The book courts readers' sympathy for the animals in this moment, making a powerful statement about how all creatures need—and deserve—to be free.



PART 2, CHAPTER 20

Nanda Kaul has become obsessed with Raka. She paces the verandah at twilight, waiting for her great-granddaughter to come home. Desperate to keep the child's attention, Nanda Kaul finds herself telling long stories again, the words spilling out in a great flood. She describes the **animals** she kept when her children were young: dogs, monkeys, and horses. She's so wrapped up in her story that she doesn't notice how dubious Raka looks. And she keeps talking with hardly a pause for breath until the owls begin to call softly. She describes the badminton court the Vice-Chancellor put in for the children.

Nanda Kaul didn't want Raka to come because she didn't want anyone to need her. But it's increasingly clear that she needs Raka more than Raka needs—or wants—her. Her insistence on isolation and solitude sounds increasingly hollow. And despite her own resentment over the feeling of being trapped by relationships and responsibilities earlier in her life, Nanda Kaul has no compunctions about trying to trap Raka with her stories.



Raka hates being stuck in the fantasy world of Nanda Kaul's nostalgia, and she longs to run away back to the charred and abandoned cottage. She yawns with boredom. Nanda Kaul interprets the yawn as fatigue.

Raka wears her feelings and beliefs simply and acts according to them. Thus, she can see that Nanda Kaul is lying to her—and to herself—by painting a rosy picture of her life. And as readers occupy Raka's viewpoint here, the book warns them not to trust Nanda Kaul's stories but to look beneath them for the painful truths she wishes to hide.



PART 2, CHAPTER 21

One afternoon, at the hour when Nanda Kaul usually takes her afternoon rest, she discovers that Raka has slipped away. Nanda Kaul feels very put out because she yearns for Raka's attention. The girl's rejection hurts and angers her. While she pouts, the phone rings, breaking Carignano's customary silence. It's Ila Das, using a rare opportunity to make a phone call to reiterate her desire to visit Nanda Kaul and Raka. Somewhat reluctantly, Nanda Kaul invites her to tea on the following afternoon.

At the end of the novel's second section, Nanda Kaul and Raka have completely switched places. Far from being a weighty responsibility, Raka is independent and self-sufficient, needing even less from Nanda Kaul than Nanda Kaul was prepared to offer her. On the other hand, Nanda Kaul's oft-denied need for attention and companionship has become painfully obvious. Because she is so focused on Raka, she misses the chance Ila Das offers her for that attention and companionship, seeing it as a distraction rather than a potential gift.



Impatiently, Nanda Kaul goes out to the verandah. She wants Ram Lal to bring her tea. She wants Raka to reappear. She stands to look out over the distant plains, then sits back down to watch the **hoopoe** strutting under the apricot trees. She thinks with disgust about the things she added to her history in her failed attempts to keep Raka's attention. She feels the urge to sweep the house clean, not for herself, but of herself.

In the previous chapter, Raka's frustration with Nanda Kaul's fantasy world suggested that readers should take the old woman's stories with a grain of salt. Now, Nanda Kaul herself insinuates that she made things up—although it's not clear where the line between truth and fiction lies—to keep Raka engaged. This, in turn, suggests a willingness to lie to herself if she sees a reason to, like sparing herself pain. Now that she's shown herself to be untrustworthy, she's warned readers to accept her words cautiously from now on—and asked to go back and reconsider what she's already said.



PART 3, CHAPTER 1

Raka considers the laden tea-table while Nanda Kaul paces the verandah, increasingly impatient over Ila Das's tardiness. Then, they notice a commotion on the road below. A flock of schoolboys surround and mercilessly taunt Ila Das as she walks toward Carignano. She shrieks threats and brandishes her ratty umbrella in their direction, but they continue. They even wrench the umbrella from her hands and try to throw it into the **ravine** before Ram Lal shouts and sends them scurrying to their homes. With dignity belied by her greying petticoat and saggy stockings, Ila Das thanks him and ascends the path to Carignano.

Ila Das's arrival comes with the kind of chaos and confusion Nanda Kaul feared from Raka—she can be seen coming from a great distance. And her vulnerability is palpable: if Nanda Kaul actually wants to take care of someone, Ila Das clearly needs help far more than Raka does. It's also important that Ila Das must ascend the mountain to reach Carignano: this and her bedraggled stockings suggest that she has fallen into a lowly place in life.



PART 3, CHAPTER 2

The scene with the schoolboys is so typical of Ila Das's life that Nanda Kaul imagines a similar crowd surrounding the infant Ila Das's pram. Nanda Kaul and Ila Das grew up together, Ila Das's "anti-social" voice a consistent theme in Nanda Kaul's early memories. When they were schoolgirls, the other children called Ila Das "Parrot," and teachers avoided calling on her. Even Ila Das's parents had disliked her voice, and they gave her piano lessons in an attempt to keep her quiet. Instead, she insisted on singing, too, her voice "like a tom-cat's in battle." Now, as she arrives for tea, Nanda Kaul reflects on how little Ila Das has changed from that little girl. And Ila throws herself into Nanda Kaul's arms with evident delight over the reunion.

Ila Das hasn't had an easy life, and the book cultivates readers' sympathy for her in part by showing the cruelty of Nanda Kaul's judgement. Nanda Kaul's ruminations suggest that Ila got stuck at some point in her development. It's worth asking why Nanda Kaul thinks of Ila Das this way: is it her excessive emotionality, her small size, her unkept appearance, or some other thing that characterizes an adult woman in Nanda Kaul's mind? Readers should pay attention to this question as Ila Das's story comes to light.



PART 3, CHAPTER 3

Nanda Kaul encourages Ila Das to move away from the gate and up the hill. Ila Das peppers her with questions and reminiscences evoked by the sight of the apricot trees. When she catches sight of Raka, she rushes over to introduce herself to the girl, shrilly promising that they'll be best friends, just like she and Nanda Kaul always have been. She even kisses Raka on the cheek, apparently blind to Raka's discomfort. Nanda Kaul notices it, feeling outraged on the child's behalf, but also a little smug that something's finally gotten under the unflappable girl's skin. Then, as Ram Lal brings out the tea, Ila Das makes herself thoroughly at home on the verandah.

Ila Das imposes herself on Carignano with a noise and confusion that's not unlike the langur monkeys. She breaks Nanda Kaul's sense of control over herself and her environment and reminds her, sharply, that chaos and upheaval are a part of life that she must accept. Nanda—and Raka—have been able to avoid confronting this fact at Carignano, with its high vistas and distance from the rest of the world. But chaos comes to Carignano in the form of Ila Das, nevertheless.



PART 3, CHAPTER 4

Ila Das immediately launches into a string of reminiscences, starting with Nanda Kaul's childhood home, where she remembers many lovely afternoon teas. Raka hates this game of rebuilding the past. She had already grown tired of her great-grandmother's stories, and now she must listen to Ila Das's. Then Ila Das remembers the piano. With a flourish, she pretends to be playing as she loudly screeches out one song after another from her youth. The sound appalls both Raka and Nanda Kaul, but Ila doesn't stop until she's ready to, wiping tears from her eyes and explaining that music always carries her away.

Ila Das's childhood memories give the lie to Nanda Kaul's imperious assertions of isolation and independence. It seems that, prior to her marriage at least, she felt no need to avoid the company of others, and she even made life-long friends. Raka hates the walk down memory lane because she sees it for what it is: a lonely old woman's attempt to resurrect her past happiness rather than face honestly her painful present. Seeing her through Raka's eyes, Ila Das looks pitiable in her desperation.



PART 3, CHAPTER 5

Undeterred by Nanda Kaul and Raka's evident lack of interest, Ila Das continues reminiscing. She's gotten to the years of Nanda Kaul's marriage now. She has fond memories of dropping by the Vice-Chancellor's house whenever she wished because she and Nanda Kaul were friends. She especially loved the badminton parties the Vice-Chancellor arranged for the faculty. Everyone did, she says, and when he and Miss David teamed up for doubles, they were unstoppable. As soon as she mentions Miss David's name, she falls silent. Raka looks up in surprise and confusion to see Ila Das and Nanda Kaul both frozen in place.

As Ila Das talks about this phase of her life, she suggests one potential cause of Nanda Kaul's antipathy: despite being an adult, she was nearly as helpless and dependent on Nanda Kaul as Nanda Kaul's own children were. And she shows an astonishing lack of sensitivity because clearly Miss David is a painful subject for Nanda Kaul. Readers might in this moment remember when Nanda Kaul described the one moment of solitude she remembers in her marriage, which insinuated that her husband was having an affair with someone.



PART 3, CHAPTER 6

Nanda Kaul rises from the table, drawing on all the training and preparation of her life to take control of herself and of the situation. She sends Raka to fetch Ram Lal so that he can clear away the tea things, and while she is gone, Nanda Kaul puts the past away and asks Ila Das about her current situation. It is not pretty, as Nanda Kaul already knows.

Throughout her tea-time reminiscences, Ila Das has emphasized her privileged past even though it's clear from her actions that she's lost some of her high-class polish. Nanda Kaul hasn't—even though her comfortable life doesn't seem to have made her any happier than her friend.



Like Nanda Kaul, Ila Das was born into a privileged family, but her brothers squandered their family's fortune. She and her sister Rima had to support themselves and their ill mother. Rima taught piano, and Nanda Kaul asked the Vice-Chancellor to create a position for Ila Das. That gave Ila Das stability, but she ultimately resigned in protest over being denied a promotion. Nanda Kaul supported this decision, but it was costly. Middle aged and with few qualifications, Ila Das nearly starved looking for another job. Once again, Nanda Kaul rescued her, directing her toward a social service course that led to a job as a government welfare worker. That job brought her to Kasauli. It's clear that Ila Das needs Nanda Kaul's help again. But Nanda Kaul has retired from helping people.

The book's earlier examples of the limitations placed on females focused on marriages—the high expectations the Vice-Chancellor had and the suggestion that he cheated on Nanda Kaul, the way Tara's husband both cheats on and abuses her—but Ila Das's sad story shows that harm can arise from other sources when women are made beholden to the choices and actions of men. Her brothers make the bad choices, and she and her sister suffer the worst consequences. Now, Nanda Kaul refuses to help her because she thinks that relaxing her isolation will cost her her freedom.



PART 3, CHAPTER 7

Raka watches from behind the hydrangeas as an animated Ila Das bounces up and down, frantically explaining to Nanda Kaul how precarious her life has become since she had to start supporting her sister Rima, too. Then she laments how poorly her coddled upbringing prepared her to face life. Nanda Kaul knows she should offer Ila Das an invitation to stay, but she cannot bear to ruin her life at Carignano, so she bites her tongue to keep from making it.

It's clear that something—a sense of responsibility, an enduring affection, or both—drives Nanda Kaul to help Ila Das. But doing so will cost her dearly because it will bring noise and chaos into her carefully ordered world. Therefore, she betrays her friend to preserve her image of herself.



PART 3, CHAPTER 8

Ila Das continues shrieking out her sad story. Life is hard for everyone in the village to which she has been assigned. And she hates the Hindu priest—not just because she herself was raised as a Christian, but because he dissuades the villagers away from seeking modern medical care. They and their children suffer and die from conjunctivitis, trachoma, and tetanus. Then, she describes her most recent campaign, against child marriage. Nanda Kaul warns Ila Das to be careful, but Ila Das refuses to back down. One of the villagers, Preet Singh, plans to marry his seven-year-old daughter to an “old man” with six children from a neighboring village in exchange for two goats. It isn’t right, Ila Das insists.

Up to this point in the novel, readers have only been privy to the privileged world of Nanda Kaul—a world in which noisy hoopoes and chaotic monkeys are the biggest threats. Ila Das points to a much larger world with much more suffering than Nanda Kaul herself has had to endure, or even imagine. She felt trapped in her own marriage but at least she wasn't married off as a child bride. The diseases Ila Das lists here are preventable and treatable but are also highly contagious and frequently lead to blindness (trachoma and conjunctivitis) or death (tetanus) if not treated. In this short chapter, the distance between Nanda Kaul's mountaintop retreat and the rest of the world becomes inescapably clear.



PART 3, CHAPTER 9

Ram Lal clears away the tea dishes as Ila Das prepares to leave. She comments about the dryness of the summer, noting that she hardly dares to light a match for fear of sparking a wildfire. Neither she nor Nanda Kaul notices Raka listening. She slips away and climbs to the top of the knoll, where she looks out over the rolling blue-grey hills and imagines herself alone on a boat in the middle of the sea. When Nanda Kaul walks Ila Das to the gate, their motion breaks her reverie. Rising, she sneaks into the kitchen, takes a box of matches, and climbs down into the **ravine**.

Raka has known her share of pain and suffering in life, as have Ila Das and Nanda Kaul. The ever-present threat of wildfires suggests, furthermore, that suffering is an inherent part of life. In answer, Raka follows her habit and slips away to one of the isolated, wild spots that give her a sense of clarity and peace. And it is perhaps this that gives her the idea to spark a fire of her own.



PART 3, CHAPTER 10

At the gate, Ila Das thanks Nanda Kaul for the tea and the afternoon’s reprieve from her exhausting life circumstances. It was like returning to the past. Nanda Kaul clearly likes this idea less than Ila Das does, so Ila Das changes the subject to Raka and Tara. Their plights remind her that she isn’t the only suffering person in the world. Bidding Nanda Kaul goodbye, she descends the hill, preparing to reshoulder her responsibilities.

Ila Das prepares to descend—literally and figuratively—from the safe and protected space of Carignano, back to the world of pain and suffering in the valley below. Her situation makes Nanda Kaul look especially selfish: she doesn't have the privilege to opt out of participating in the world, and her responsibilities—preventing child marriage, trying to modernize attitudes toward healthcare—are far weightier than Nanda Kaul's hostess duties as the Vice-Chancellor's wife.



Nanda Kaul watches Ila Das—and the “horrors” she brought with her—slowly disappear. She doesn’t know how Ila Das hangs on despite the precarity of her existence. She knows that she should help her friend. She looks out protectively for any more taunting schoolboys, staying where she is because she sees no lurking dangers. When she can no longer see Ila Das, relief washes over her. She feels that she has faced three tests of her composure and her autonomy—Ila Das’s thoughtless invocation of Miss David, the feeling that she should invite Ila Das to stay at Carignano, and her urge just now to follow and protect her friend—and has passed all three.

Nanda Kaul returns to the garden where she paces restlessly. She wishes for Raka to appear but knows the girl won’t. She admires a day lily in bloom. A praying mantis climbs onto the flower under her watchful eyes. She dislodges the insect with a flick of her fingers, sending it into the leaves where it will be safe from the birds.

Nanda Kaul feels torn between two competing impulses: the first to turn away from the horror show that is her friend’s life, the second to protect the hapless Ila Das from further harm. She experiences the interactions of the afternoon as “tests” because she still associates freedom with isolation and feels determined to do anything necessary to maintain her autonomy. The effort she must put into this suggests that it might actually be contrary to her nature.



Having passed the test of Ila Das, Nanda Kaul immediately wishes for Raka’s company, suggesting that she truly doesn’t want to be isolated—she just doesn’t want to feel like she’s being pulled back into the world of responsibilities and expectations that she lived in when she was married. Flicking the bug into the ground—even allegedly to protect it—suggests that she’s capable of great cruelty in the name of what she thinks is right.



PART 3, CHAPTER 11

Feeling cheerful after tea, Ila Das doesn’t go straight home but heads to the bazaar instead, hoping she can afford to buy some corn meal or potatoes for her dinner. As she bobs down the path, tourists and schoolgirls laugh at her, and a boy rudely shoves her out of his way. She doesn’t notice because she’s daydreaming about getting a job at the Pasteur Institute. By the time she has reached the bazaar, however, the rude treatment is starting to wear on her. She blinks back tears and tries to hold her head high, drawing on the dignity her upbringing instilled in her.

Only the grainseller treats Ila Das with respect. He’s always kind to her and always throws in some garlic or chilies for free when she shops at his stall. Tonight, she asks the price of cornmeal, and although it’s higher than she can afford, she clings to her dignity and pretends to nonchalantly change her mind. Telling the shopkeeper that she’ll be back another day, she turns to go home. He expresses concern over the idea of her walking home alone in the dark, but she insists that she is always alone and never afraid. As she disappears into the bazaar’s crowds, the grainseller thinks of the conversation he had earlier in the day with Preet Singh, and that man’s anger.

Ila Das’s visit to Carignano buoys her spirit. But the idyll isn’t enough to offset her dire circumstances. The casual cruelty of people emphasizes her sorry state and makes Nanda Kaul’s cruelty in sending her away ever more noticeable. Her privileged upbringing gave her a sense of dignity and pride, but that alone isn’t enough to protect her from the harshness of the world. And the ill-treatment she suffers cultivates readers’ empathy for her plight.



Even though the book cultivates pity for Ila Das, the way she clings to her high-class airs seems pathetic given her dire circumstances. The only thing she has left is her pride, but indulging it renders her even more vulnerable than ever. Like Nanda Kaul, she insists on maintaining an image of herself and her life that doesn’t fit her reality. And the grainseller’s warning foreshadows the dangers inherent in this lack of self-awareness or respect for reality.



Despite her proud words, Ila Das fights rising panic as she hobbles toward her home in the growing dark. She shakes her head in consternation, causing her hairdo to collapse and making her look even more disheveled. She tries to cheer herself up by reminding herself of how she was raised. She feels a flash of pride that she, her father's daughter has not ever and will not ever be in debt to a "hairy, half-dressed shopkeeper" like the grainseller, and in the next instant criticizes herself for the classist way she still tends to think even though she's no longer wealthy or privileged. She comes to a fork in the road and hurries on toward her village.

Ila Das spends her days trying to drag ill-educated villagers into the era of modern medicine and marriage practices, and it's a source of enduring frustration to her that it isn't easier to change their ways. But her instinctive repulsion toward the kind grainseller shows how hard it can be to shed those old narratives. Clinging to her old ways doesn't serve her any more than the villager's insistence on folk medicine protects their health, but these deeply ingrained attitudes are nearly impossible to change.



PART 3, CHAPTER 12

Ila Das rushes down the path hoping to make it home before it's fully dark. Although the valley in which she lives is dusky, sunlight still burnishes the ridge high above—where Carignano sits—golden. The day had been hot, but the air is rapidly cooling. Ila Das shivers in the rising mist. She thinks about how sad it is to be old, alone, and destitute. She doesn't know how much longer she will be able to bear it. In the growing darkness, birds settle into the trees for the night, and everything grows still and silent. Ila Das becomes keenly aware of herself as the only moving thing in the landscape. She wishes she had been able to forget her pride long enough to ask Nanda Kaul for help, or to beg the grainseller for charity.

The description of Ila Das's descent suggests how far she's fallen in life—she who started out on the same level as Nanda Kaul. She thinks of herself and her dire straits badly, yet the book tacitly criticizes Nanda Kaul (who is away on her untouchable, golden mountain) for failing to help a friend in need even though she knew she should. This contributes to Ila Das's sense of isolation—technically, she has a friend. But practically, she might as well be the only person in the world at this moment.



Ila Das is almost running as she rounds the last bend in the road and comes in sight of the tiny, destitute hamlet where she lives in a flea-ridden little hovel. Then, a shadow rises from the side of the road and Preet Singh grabs her by the throat. Although she fends him off for a moment, he quickly overpowers her. He strangles her to death with her own scarf, tears off her clothing, and viciously rapes her.

In her old age, Nanda Kaul chose to protect herself by withdrawing as completely as possible from the world. Prevented by her circumstances from making a similar choice, Ila Das embraces helping others—her sister, the little girls of her village. In the end, she does the thing Nanda Kaul is afraid to do: she pays for her service with her life. Yet, the book presents her in this moment as the nobler of the two women. And, of course, her vulnerability to Preet Singh's violence emphasizes the difficulty and danger of living in a society that devalues women.



PART 3, CHAPTER 13

High up on the hill, Nanda Kaul bristles with anger as the insistent ringing of the phone breaks the newly restored silence of Carignano. She pointedly ignores it. Ram Lal answers, then quickly summons her to the phone. With irritation, she sweeps into the house and picks up the receiver. A police officer is on the other end of the line. He needs her to come and identify Ila Das's body. Brusquely, he explains that some villagers just found her raped, mutilated corpse on the side of the road.

All this time, Nanda Kaul has believed that she could remove herself from the world of responsibilities, relationships, and suffering, and that by the force of her will, she could render herself unreachable and untouchable. She could ignore the calls of others if she only tried hard enough. The revelation of Ila Das's death shatters that illusion.



Nanda Kaul drops the phone receiver. She does not want to believe what she hears. She wants it to be a lie, just like the stories she told Raka. Her father never traveled to Tibet or kept exotic animals. The Vice-Chancellor never loved her—he just tried to keep her quiet about his lifelong affair with Miss David. She never cherished or understood her children. And doesn't want to live alone. Ila Das lied about her needs. Why can't this horror be a lie too? Just then, Raka materializes from the darkness, summoning Nanda Kaul to witness the wildfire she's started. But her Nani sits motionless next to the phone, her head hanging. In the **ravine**, the fire roars through the dry grass and trees, racing up the mountain.

Now, finally, Nanda Kaul admits outright that the stories she told Raka—and herself—were lies. Too late, she sees the harm in trying to avoid reality, no matter how painful reality is. Raka resurfaces at this moment, revealing that she's set a wildfire in the ravine. This fire further threatens the life Nanda Kaul has so carefully created. The recent tragedy and the impending catastrophe both force Nanda Kaul to confront the truth and herself. Suffering is unavoidable, and her attempts to avoid it have only made things worse for herself and for others.





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